

PASSING THROUGH — COHEN BENJAMIN



Passing Through

Cohen Benjamin

(as ghostwritten by Quinn Tyler Jackson)

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A stylized, handwritten signature of Quinn Tyler Jackson in black ink.

CHAPTER ONE

He took another drag from his cigarette, held the smoke in his mouth until it became stale, and shot it straight at the pane. A ring of smoke shot back towards him as soon as it hit the glass and shattered as though cold in the frigid mountain air. Through the wafts of smoke he could see the beginnings of a new day in the life of the villagers.

The village was a collection of two-story stone houses clinging to the side of a valley of rusty rock. At the bottom of the valley ran a tiny waterway—no more than a creek, but Abadoun's only steady source of water. Most of the houses—shacks—had windows only on the second floor, and very few of these windows had panes; the glass in front of him was an indication that the caravanserai he stayed at during his visits was once an important guest house. Some shacks had small pipes coming out their roofs—the lucky villagers had fashioned furnaces out of whatever they could gather together.

Seeing the pipes reminded him to turn the coals in the brazier, and after he had stirred the fire some and warmed his hands, he returned to the window and watched a young boy nearly pushing his overloaded mule up the side of the valley. To make it up to one of the higher shacks, the villagers had to wind up the many twisted, labyrinthine pathways of loose gravel.

As the sun rose, its rays did not reach the windows of the shacks; only in its apex did the village receive light. Even without full daylight, however, he could see the boulders and stones everywhere—in the streets, in the alleyways, on the roofs of the houses. The houses themselves were built of stone, some of the older ones have no mortar between the stones. The overall impression of Abadoun, like so many other terrace villages of its kind, was that it had come out of the stone of the mountain itself.

"Hiroshima in stained glass," he mumbled in Kurdish, so the words were thick with his Persian accent; he had no

reason for his accent to come out less when around her. His throat began to tickle when the chill of the air defeated the warmth of the fumes, so he took another deep drag to warm up.

“Pardon me?” she said, rolling over in the sheets to look at him with her brown, comforting eyes. Her features were those of the painted wine bearers of a million ancient quatrains: the large eyes, the tiny lips, the long, raven hair, the eyelashes that could trip a man.

“I was just looking at everything down there—the people,” he said, jerking his hand in the direction of the street below. “What few there are these days. I remember when the streets were filled with them. I didn’t stand out so much then. Now, I’m beginning to wonder if I’ll start to raise suspicion out there on the street.”

She slid over to the side of the bed, clinging to the sheet for its warm cover more than out of modesty. “The Kurds are a proud people....”

“Enough sociology. Pride is the creed of dead generals and peacock kings. The whole of Kurdistan is as good as buried,” he said, tapping his cigarette with his callused finger so that the ashes fell on the windowsill before him.

She started to put on her heavy assortment of clothes that made her distinctly Kurdish and distinctly Muslim at once. He vaguely understood that the way she was intricately tying her headdress told all others that she was unwed and available for marriage if the dowry was right, and he knew that her sash, the color of her numerous overcoats—indeed, every article of clothing she put on in its proper order—told something of a tale of her status, parentage, and place in the clan hierarchy, but he was not Kurdish and could not read the colors and fabrics and knots. He knew the naked her, the her under the fabric, and didn’t really want to know the her that was about to go out into the village life. He took another drag and again tossed his ashes onto the now one-third hidden sill.

He laughed. “I won’t be needing another pouch of these Turkish pieces of shit,” he said, pointing at the half-empty

package of cigarettes on the nightstand. He again looked out the window and down at the Kurds in the narrow streets below. "All I'd have to do is drink from the stream a few miles from here, and—"

"You're perverse," she hissed, at the same time gesturing with her hand that she dismissed his words as nonsense. By now, she was fully attired in her cumbersome autumn clothing and ready to slip out of the room and back into daily town life until afternoon. "Negative and perverse."

"You know these people, and that makes you feel for them," he said, still sucking hard at his cigarette. "I only pass through now and again on my way to Saqqez, so I see very clearly how their numbers dwindle." He smiled at her and the smoke rose satanically from his mouth. He pointed down at an old man. "Take that man down there, for instance. I remember him from a year ago, when he had three young boys at his side as he hobbled down the street. This time as I'm passing through, I see that he's alone. No more boys."

"Passing through," she whispered, stretching her hand to point at the messy bed sheets.

"Oh, spare me," he groaned. "You knew when you swore allegiance to *Azadi* that your comfort would come in small portions." He turned and noticed the other women out the window as they wandered below, covered and faceless. "You take what comfort you can get from any passing Majnoun." He wanted his back to be to her so that she could not see the helplessness that he knew must be clear on his face, now that the smoke had cleared enough for her to get a good look at him.

“Alf Leila wa Leili”

Will you warm some other bed tomorrow?
You know well your hold on me is thorough;
If I my soul now auction quick away,
Will I with you one more moment borrow?

She opens the thin wooden door. He is standing there at the threshold with an opened pouch of cigarettes. One of the cigarettes hangs from his almost blue lips. The hours of driving show on his wide whisker-covered face and in the hang of his shoulders. She reaches out to help him, but then pulls back her hand so that he won't think that she is suggesting he cannot carry himself. She has heard about the bullet; she wants to help, but she knows he is a proud man and will accept neither sympathy nor assistance from her.

“You're finally here,” she says.

His heavy, black eyebrows rise a bit, quiver a moment, and return to their usual position. He saunters into the stale air of the room, places his pouch of cigarettes on the bed, his suitcase on the floor, and removes his thick autumn coat. She remarks to herself as she looks at his hefty frame that he does not seem to favor either side in any way but that he does seem more premeditated in his movement than she remembers his ever having been.

“I heard about it. Which side did the bullet enter?” she inquires.

“The right,” he replies before sitting on the bed and lighting up another cigarette with an almost ritualized gesture. The bed groans under his weight. “It hit me square in the right side and knocked me off my feet with a sickening Dervish spin. It's amazing how even a wounded man can run like the wind when he's being chased, mind you, so I lived.”

She does not like the smoke in the air; it stings her eyes and bothers her nose. She brushes her hand in front of her face in an attempt to swish away the fumes of his habit. "Dirty cigarettes!" she says. "Why do you smoke so much? And with your injury and everything you..."

"Turkish," he says, proudly holding out the burning, stinking stick in front of himself. "I bought these in Baghdad from a nurse while I was recovering. I wasn't allowed to smoke while I was in convalescence, you know, so I'm catching up on lost time."

His voice sounds heavy and deliberate, like the voice of a man who is desperate for a breath of air but cannot get one no matter how hard he inhales. He has always sounded like this to some degree, but he seems more desperate now than ever before. She moves toward him, wanting to give him a show of her affection, but she knows he will not accept it; he never has before.

She knows many things about him that he does not have any idea she knows. She knows his real name. His place of birth. His education. She knows enough about him to have fallen in love with him. Most of all, however, she knows that he will not accept her affection, and this saddens her, but she understands both of their commitments to the life they have chosen to live.

He knows her as only as *Leili*, as if she is no more than the first name on a tale told in teahouses by those versed in Ferdowsi's *Book of Kings*. To him, she is a courtesan for the cause. A comforter. The mistress waiting at the caravanserai to replenish him according to the custom of their secret society. She is more than a courtesan, but he has no concept of this and she chooses not to take his illusion away from him, since she knows that he has formed this idea of her not out of malice but as a means of self-preservation, a motive she recognizes within herself as well.

"What have you heard about your next mission? Anything at all?" she asks. She understands that he has no obligation whatsoever to tell her anything about his

missions. Moreover, she already understands more about his next assignment into Teheran than he ever will, even when he has completed it, since her position in *Cheshman-e-Azadi* is not as lowly and ill-informed as he has always chosen to believe. She has asked for information from him for no other reason than her desire to hear his heavy voice. He is really her comforter, but he thinks things are the other way around, and she has never led him to suspect otherwise, so he will not deny her even those comforts she steals from him.

"Our other eye will tell me tomorrow morning when I visit him," he says, making the gesture of drinking tea. "I have no idea why I'm going into Teheran this time, but then again, I never do at this point, do I?" He massages his ribs. "Most likely, it will be a mission not unlike a dozen missions I've already completed this year. I just hope I don't end up in another Iraqi hospital over it, or worse."

"You are the best of us," she says. She is not deceiving or flattering him. He has never failed *Azadi*; his recovery record is perfect. His manners want refining, but only when the doors are closed and no one can see him, and there are no *Azadi* oaths about such things as manners.

"And I am sore," he returns, lying back onto the bed, still massaging his ribs. "Very sore, indeed." He closes his eyes and rubs them with his hands. "But, then, I don't suspect you know how sore I am. Have you ever been hit by a bullet?"

She waits a long time before answering. "Never. I imagine it is very painful. I can hear it in your breathing, in the way you talk. And I remember the public executions." She wants to say more about what she knows of the sound of a bullet hitting flesh, but she knows he will not understand how she could know that sound.

"Well, I am still tender. And this after I've already had a bit of time to recuperate," he says, still rubbing his eyes. "Imagine how I felt even a week ago, lying on a torn cot in a stinking hospital hallway. Yes, it is a painful proposition. It made me promise myself that I will always shoot to kill

from now on, for mercy's sake. I don't have the heart to let even the enemy suffer through a recovery like mine has been these last weeks. There is room in our fight for a bit of mercy, don't you think, Leili? Those stinking hallways...."

"I was happy to hear that you were alive, at least," she replies, not used to hearing compassionate words from him. "I heard that you had one foot in the land of the living and the other in the land of the dead."

"Yes, I suppose I did at that." His cigarette continues to pour out rancid smoke into the room. "What news have you for me, then?" he asks. "It's been some time since my last run through here."

She understands that he does not really think she has any useful information for him. He is asking out of politeness and his custom. "I know nothing much about anything," she lies to him. She knows that this is the lie he really wants to hear, for this is the lie that has always satisfied him before, and she has no reason to believe that he wants to hear any different now.

"Then tell me a story," he says with a smile. The smoke is pouring out of his nostrils, but it does not seem to be bothering him as much as it bothers her, even with his injury.

"Story?"

"Yes, a story. I'd like to hear you tell me a fable."

"Well, I know a few classic tales, but I'm not tale-teller. Which fable would you like to hear?" she asks as she sits beside him on the bed. She knows that he will have her body as the night becomes darker, and she doesn't mind giving him the comfort he needs, but she is happy that he has asked for a story from her, since she wants to give him more than her body and her bosom, even if just for the time being. She wants to give him some of her knowledge—knowledge that he can't take with a few of his thrusts.

"Well, let's see. You can be my Princess Sharzad, then? Why not? Can you keep me in a trance for a thousand and one nights with your stories?" he asks. "Tell me what has been happening in the daily life of Abadoun since my visit,

to begin with.” He continues to rub his eyes, as if they have sand in them, but more likely because they are tired beyond comprehension.

“You know very well that life in Abadoun changes only rarely,” she admits. “Has it ever been different? What you know from your last visit applies today as well, and very well may apply in ten thousand tomorrows.” She puts her hand on his chest and massages the hard flesh under his shirt. “Tomorrow, Abadoun will be as it always has been, as surely as Shah was crowned in Persepolis.”

“Will it?” he replies. “Will it be the same Abadoun in ‘ten thousand tomorrows,’ as you put it? God has put his finger down heavily on this town before, there’s nothing to stop him from doing so again. I wonder if it will be the same village even tomorrow, let alone ten thousand years.”

She always expects him to be antagonistic, but she has not expected this. She sighs from disbelief that he questions the static nature of life in the tiny village, for she knows that he is well aware that nothing that would concern him ever happens while he is away. “What could change here?” she asks. “I think my father, Mullah Aziz, and I are the only ones who can even read so much as a line from a book. If knowledge is the root of all change, what could change under these conditions? The whole cycle of things has been finely tuned by *Kaaks* and Shahs to remain as it has always been. Besides, *Azadi* is quite happy that the town remains the same from year to year. It gives us a place to roost without drawing suspicion from suspicious minds. This is part of the reason we have operatives here.” She realizes that she has betrayed her understanding of the workings of the organization and that her knowledge of *Azadi* may now appear more complete than he may like, but feels safe that he will not take note of her slip.

He hesitates and she feels his body become tense under her hands, as if he is about to explode and is trying to hold in the shrapnel. “I mean, have any soldiers or even Islamic Revolutionary Guards been through here lately? Has the shelling nearby towns grown closer? Has the mullah or his

assistant Rezai, or whatever his name is, been sniffing about with a nose for trouble? Are the people in the streets talking about different things at all? These types of things. Things that people do when there is tension in the air.”

“There is always the stink of fear and tension in the air these days, but, there is none of that other stuff. No Guards. The shelling is constant, but distant. Mullah Aziz is too old to create any more trouble than he already has, and his assistant is fine if left to his own corrupt devices. How about that tale now?” she asks.

“Ah, yes, the tale!” he says, closing his quaking eyelids.

“I’ll tell you the tale of Mohammad Ali Shamlou, then. There once was, there once wasn’t...,” she begins. It is a long tale, and finally, when she is finished, she suggests that he should sleep.

He opens his eyes and looks into hers. “I will sleep later,” he answers her. “I’ve never heard the tale of Ali Shamlou before,” he said. “Who told you that one? It’s very odd, indeed.”

“My father is an old, learned man,” she replies as he kisses her hand, “and old, learned men know many tales. I heard it from him, more or less.” She does not turn away his advances; she never has. He thinks she is there for his comfort and nothing else, and she does not desire to lead him to believe otherwise. She pulls open his shirt and slowly removes it. She sees the scar, which is still red and pulls her head back a bit to examine it more completely.

“You are lucky to be alive after a thing like that,” she says, stroking his bare chest. “People have died of less.”

* * *

Afterwards, she falls asleep and dreams she and he are walking down the streets of the village in full view of everyone, dressed in traditional wedding attire. The frenzied howls of the crowd fill the crisp mountain air, echo out into the hills around the village, and come back mixed with the enthusiastic music of the many musicians.

Her dream is of a time before the war, when the town was full of fine young men and happy mothers in the warm breeze of autumn, when weddings were a town festival, not an arrangement made between crippled soldiers and orphaned daughters. It is a dream of a time now so far away from her that only in a dream could she see it again, for she knows that the ethereal villagers who cheer for her have long since been dead at the hands of Iraqi soldiers.

“Praise God!” cries the town mullah. “May His hand be in this marriage!”

“Many sons!” cries the crowd. “God give them many sons!”

There is no sadness or loneliness in the dream and they are soon away from the feasting guests and at their wedding bed, making love the way she wants, rather than the way he insists when she isn’t dreaming. As he has her in their wedding bed, she can see his face, see real passion and affection in his eyes, and kiss his lips with all the tenderness she wants to give him, and in her dream, he accepts and returns tenderness in kind. There is more to each of his thrusts into her than pain, lust, perversion, and loneliness.

When they have made love, she dresses in purple and pink with a veil of dangling coins and a stripped headdress, and they parade down the streets of the village with the blood-stained sheets as her virginity token. Indeed, even after so many trips through the village in his car and so many nights at the caravanserai, she could still give him such a token, since he has never had need to take her maiden’s head to have what he wants of her. He has made sure to preserve her verifiable honor, should she ever marry a shepherd in the town and have to produce such a token in her waking life. Were he ever to take her that way, he would still be taking a maiden, however much else of her body and soul she had compromised for him.

In the dream, however, the wedding night is truly a night of innocence and beginnings, and she is proud to have her chastity declared before all the village as the girl with

the bright lantern runs down the street ahead of them to scare away all darkness from the bond. The words of the books on feminism and equality and male brutality mean nothing to her in light of marrying the man she loves and giving him her chastity as a dowry, for although her mind struggles for the realization of slogans, her heart is content with nostalgic dreams of how things might have been for her without a Revolution, without a war, without a *Cheshman-e-Azadi*.

“She was a maiden!” her mother hollers out into the hills, grabbing hold of the sheet from them and waving it madly about the crowd so that none may doubt it.

They sit around a great table with all the guests. The ceremonial wedding jug sits before her, filled with water. Atop the job is the smaller job, the one symbolizing birth giving. The potter has made it especially for her, and the women of the village have decorated it with pink and blue ribbons and frills.

Then she and he are alone at the table in the middle of the marketplace. Everyone else has gone inside and darkness has come upon the town. The lantern-bearer has gone, too, so that there is no light at all except the light of the thousands of stars above the valley. She holds tightly to his sleeve so as to have something to refer to in order not to lose her balance.

“What is it?” she asks. “What’s happening?”

He does not reply, but instead looks away from her and tries to pull away from her, as he always does in these dreams. The sunlight shines through the window of the caravanserai and hits her face as all the dream world around her disintegrates back into her heart, burned away by morning’s reality.

She is soon fully awake. He has left her alone under the covers. The room is chillier than it had been the night before, but she sees that he has relit the coals in the brazier. He is at the window, dressed, smoking, and breathing crystals onto the glass.

“Hiroshima in stained glass,” he says quietly to himself, but she hears him.

“Pardon me?” she says, rolling over in the sheets to look at him more closely. She knows of Hiroshima from having read her father’s books. In the morning light he looks more as he does in her dreams, although he never smokes in her fantasies.

“I was just looking at all the people down there,” he says. “What few there are now. I remember when the streets were filled with them. I didn’t stand out so much then. Now, I’m beginning to ask myself if I’ll start to raise suspicion out there on the street.”

She slides over to the side of the bed, clinging to the sheet in an attempt to keep the chilly air off her naked skin. The sheet makes her think of her mother and the reverie she has just awakened from. She is alarmed that he even takes the time to examine the villagers, since it is not his usual way to care at all. “The Kurds are a proud people—”

“Enough ethnography. Pride is the creed of dead generals and peacock kings. All Kurdistan is as good as buried,” he says.

He has used a Farsi expression best suited for the halls of academia: *iran-shenassy*. Her mind can only find “ethnography” in its storeroom of possible meanings. *As good as buried*, he has said. He is always saying pessimistic things like this, and even in his broken Kurdish, his sourness spills into his words. He has the right to be sour hearted, though, she tells herself, since he is putting his soul on God’s auction block for these Kurds he hardly understands, and for those like them.

She wants to tell him to be quiet but feels obligated to let him speak his mind. He *has* been shot recently, she knows, and has reason to be depressed, since depression often follows such things. She starts to dress as quickly as she can, in a race against the cold. She can hear his puffing at his cigarette. Despite her understanding of him, she can feel herself becoming annoyed at his sooty attitude about everything. Her heart is sour towards him and she wants to

yell at him as loudly as any other woman who had just been used like a prostitute.

He suddenly laughs very enthusiastically, and as he does so, his heavy frame jumps about under his clothes. "I won't be needing another pouch of these Turkish pieces of shit," he says, pointing at the cigarettes on the table. He again looks out the window. "All I'd have to do is drink from the stream a few miles from here, and—"

Her pulse quickens until she can feel her heart pounding against her chest. He knows nothing of her even after having been with her—having had her flesh—so many times. It means nothing to him that she is also a woman, besides being an agent of *Azadi*. This angers her more, until she can no longer contain her rage. "You're perverse," she hisses like a provoked cobra. She is fully attired in her heavy assortment of clothing and ready to slip out of the room and back into town life. Her veil shows her clan loyalties and her status as a spinster but hides her scorn. "Negative and perverse," she adds with clenched fists, ready to hit him hard if he approaches her at all.

"You know these people, and that makes you feel for them," he explains, sucking his cigarette with an anxious intensity she has never seen before, even in him. "I only pass through now and again on my way to Saqqez, so I see very clearly how their numbers dwindle. Take that man down there, for instance. I remember him from a year ago, when he had three young boys at his side as he hobbled down the street. This time as I'm passing through, I see that he's alone. No more boys."

"Passing through," she whispers, stretching her hand to point at the messy bed sheets. She knows that this will mean nothing to him, for in his mind, she is his comforter and no one more. His comfort for the cause. A constant woman to come to and have for an inconstant man who dares not take any woman as his wife. She is nothing else that he can know of, so she cannot expect him to have his methodical sentiments touched by what she means to say to him. Although enraged, she is content deep inside that the

veil is covering her face because she does not want him to see the ferocity of her anger.

"Oh, spare me," he says to her. "You knew when you swore allegiance to *Azadi* that your comfort would come in small portions. You take what comfort you can get from any passing Majnoun."

This angers her more, but somehow some part of her that she finds no pride in harboring is happy that he seems to understand that she, too, gets some of her comfort from him. He has never suggested any understanding of this before. She knows that in many ways he is right to say that she knows what to expect from her oath to the organization, but she wants to scream at him anyway because he knows nothing of the true nature and depth of her allegiance to *Azadi* and yet he claims to know her role. He has had her as not even a husband ought to and she has consented to this debasing treatment, but only for his comfort. She knows he cannot marry, and so gives her body to him to keep him from temptation and lonely despair's doorstep. She knows that he thinks that it goes no further than that, but she also knows that his understanding is far from complete, and that he must be forgiven his blindness. At least he has this one time, even though intending to insult her, admitted that she, too, takes her solace from him.

She leaves the room with her teeth grinding together. No one will see her anger under the cover of her veil, and she is glad of this. To be used by an ignorant man is one thing, but to have her allegiance to *Azadi* questioned is altogether different, for she has given more than her life to the Eyes of Freedom. He does not grasp any more of her than suits his needs, any more than he can fit comfortably into his hands; he is only one of the Eyes of Freedom, and as a single Eye, he sees imperfectly. His limited vision is the reason he has never been more than a body smuggler, rather than an assassin or coordinator. She knows that good body smugglers are rare, but good assassins even rarer; an assassin must believe in the tenets of *Azadi* so intimately that the blood stains on the soul do not show on the flesh.

As she walks past the refuse behind the building, none of it foul smelling, since the mountain air is cold and keeps it from rotting quickly, she wonders how he would react if he discovered that she knew his real name and his life history from all of his night chatter. Over the years she has learned a great deal from him as he talks in his sleep.

She wonders how he would react if he knew of her true activities for *Azadi*. Would it surprise him to know that, only a week earlier, she bound what he called “divine” breasts tightly and painfully to her body, put her long hair under a man’s bandana, and dressed in a man’s clothes in order to go by cover of night to sap the bridge five miles into Iraqi territory? Her culture relies so much on what one wears that even a woman, sufficiently dressed and appropriately adorned in the wool vest with angled horns protruding from the shoulders, can look like a shepherd from a distance. From far enough away, she could look like a rich married woman just by changing the knots in her headdress and sash. Had he ever been close enough to her to tell the difference?

Does he know that she was the one who killed the seven Iraqi soldiers in the transport that went over the weakened structure? Perhaps he has heard of the incident, but has he any notion that his consort was the one who then approached the downed vehicle to cut the throats of those who were still alive after the fall? Does he know that she prays every day to God to preserve her soul that she may come out of the nightmare and still attain paradise? He knows nothing of her other than what he gropes under the covers, and for the most part, he knows only as much as she is comfortable with him knowing.

She quickens her pace until she is at the entrance of the ragged alleyway. Until now, she has been behind the caravanserai and no one can have seen her. When she steps out into the traffic of similarly veiled pedestrians, she is no longer angry; there is no room for hostility in the anonymity that is daily life for a veiled woman of Abadoun.

As she walks toward her goal, she loses her concentration and bumps into another woman on the street. She jerks her head back to look, since she can see nothing well up close because of her heavy veil. She sees that the woman she has bumped into is heavy with child, and she becomes angry at him again. He can give her no children; she is there for his succor, and he knows nothing else of the matter. After her anger subsides, she tries to recognize who she has stopped, but she cannot tell from the clothes alone, since so many of the women of the village wear the same colors. She was born in Abadoun, is married—she didn't need a headdress to tell her what the pregnant belly did—and was of a position equal to her own socially. This told her nothing of the woman's identity.

"I am stupid!" she says to the pregnant lady.

"God is merciful," the lady returns before continuing on her way.

She is quickly at another alleyway, waiting for the boy. She paid him twenty *tuman* the day before to take her father's mule to Baneh, get supplies, and return to this meeting place. She has also given the boy a week's supply of rice so that his family may eat, since she knows he has two younger sisters who have been in poor health. When he finally arrives, she thanks him quietly and leads the mule down the back ways. The mule has sure footing, but occasionally she slips on a loose stone as they go down the side of the valley towards the creek and the marketplace.

"You have finally returned from Baneh, my daughter!" her father exclaims as she enters the rear door of his small shop. He is a ruddy, educated man whose gray eyebrows, bent neck, twisted moustache, and bald head give him the distinction of years. Always eager to hold her and give her his affection, he embraces her. "I had been worried that..." he begins but does not finish. "These terrible days of war and strife, you know, I feel bad that you must always..."

Her father also knows nothing of her but she is not angry at him for this, since he is an old exile in his last years and should not know these things. She returns his

embrace and sets herself to her tasks in the shop. She knows that he thinks she has been on an overnight journey to Banah for supplies. She has paid the boy to do these things for her, in order that she give comfort to the man who thinks she is only there for his comfort.

As she squats on the worn carpet that covers the bare earth that is the floor of the shop, she skillfully picks the pebbles from the afternoon rice, she remembers the throats of the five men she killed. Two were killed upon hitting the jagged, knife-sharp rocks below, and for that she was happy, since she did not have to finish them herself. The others were unconscious when she reached them, which made her task effortless to complete, but she wonders if the blood will ever wash from her fingers or if her place in Hell will be particularly fiery.

What did he say? “You knew when you swore allegiance to *Azadi* that your comfort would come in small portions.” She needs his comfort more than he needs hers; he is a man she is not asked to kill, a murderer for a cause she also murders for. A lover. A terrible lover, but a lover, nonetheless. A thankless lover, but still, a lover. He is the only man she has anything in common with, yet even he knows nothing of her missions as an assassin or of the coordinating that she takes part in for the *Azadi*. She knows that secrecy within the organization has kept this knowledge from him so that the leaders cannot be identified under torture. For his service, he gets her as his personal *hourri* while still on Earth—for her service, she gets to be his unidentifiable commander.

She continues to pick at the rice many more minutes, sometimes missing the pebbles because of her distraction. This daily ritual has become her time for reflection. The pebbles are quickly tossed into a small jar. No one has ever bit a stone at her father’s table.

“You forgot to buy saffron,” her father notices. “I was careful to ask you to remember saffron, and you were not careful to mind my words, *Baba*.”

Her mind races at this revelation. She now recalls that she forgot to mention saffron to the boy, in her haste to steal away to the caravanserai before he arrived in his car. She has failed her father only a little bit, but it hurts her to have forgotten, and she misses a pebble and tosses a grain of good rice into the jar instead.

"I am stupid and thoughtless," she says, striking her cloth covered forehead with the palm of one of her hands.

"*Aziz-am*, you are my only child," he says in Farsi, his native tongue. "Do not pain your hand for me."

Dast-et dard na koneh, she thinks in the language that is mostly foreign to her ears. She learned Kurdish from her mother, and only has a passing understanding of spoken Farsi; her knowledge of the Persian language is book knowledge. She has pained her hand for him, and those like him. She has stained her hands with soldiers' blood for him and alienated herself from the God she had, as an innocent child, once wanted to please with all her heart.

She has always picked the pebbles out of the rice for her father. He was a teacher in Tabriz. An honorable man, until he tried to teach his students in cellars instead of State schools. Then he was a prisoner, until they finally let him out, and sent him to Abadoun in exile with his wife. That her father may live the rest of his days in relative peace she has pained her hand for him. That he does not even have his prison taken from him, she has pained her hand for him.

"You have pained *your* hand for me," she returns in her more natural Kurdish. "I am stupid. I will remember to buy twice as much saffron next time, from my own money that I have saved up."

"Money means less and less these days. Take the money from the store, or whatever—do what you must to feel right about it," he says. "We shall serve our guests something else tonight on the rice. Turmeric, perhaps—we have plenty of that. I only hope your mother won't be angry about such short notice. She may not be so forgiving of your oversight, and my ears will be boxed," he laughs. He is a gentle man

and will let his wife box his ears, and he will laugh then, too.

She wonders if, like her exiled parents, her career as a rebel will eventually amount to a life in the twilight years worrying about substituting turmeric for saffron on the guests' rice in the throes of war. She continues her task. He is walking up the street in front of the shop, and she knows he is not allowed to look into the shop at her. From behind her veil she can look right at him, however, and she sees that he appears almost sad. She has never seen this face before.

"When will you ever find an honest man to marry?" her father starts as he unpacks the supplies she has brought him. "Certainly not in this town," he says almost to himself. "Abadoun has honest women, maybe, but honest men? Look at us! Shopkeepers selling to other shopkeepers. It's perverted."

"I have noticed that," she says.

"Except when we have to go to Baneh for supplies, our *tuman* never make it out of the hands of four or five old men here in Abadoun. Just yesterday someone paid me with a bill that I had paid him with. I knew because I had written on it for lack of other paper." He laughs again. He is always laughing. "The *bazaari* are the only ones left here and they certainly aren't marrying stock. Old men, with children your age already. Maybe back in the day, when it did not matter who or how many one married. Did I ever tell you how your mother and I met in Tabriz? Now, that was different."

"It was very nice," she says. "*Mama* has told me the story many times."

"I was a teacher there," he says, rubbing a tear from the leathery bag under his eye. "Not what you'd want." He wants her to go to Tabriz and marry there when the war is over. He has been saving up for the trip. Marry an honest Azari man. Not a teacher or shopkeeper or revolutionary thinker. "Just don't marry a man like your father," he warns her with a wide, toothless smile. "Keep away from my kind

in Tabriz, and you'll be better off for it, I assure you. Keep away from anyone who even smells like me."

"I will marry whom God wills when He wills it," she replies. "No sooner, no later, no one else, *ensh-Allah*."

"Well, at least you are an honest woman, *Aziz-am*," he says. He sits. He looks tired. "Now, put aside that rice for a moment. Get back to it later when you've had some tea."

The tea is ready and he pours her some. "Tell me about the trip to Baneh, *Baba*."

He has not been allowed to leave the town since his exile there many years earlier, but she has been to Baneh enough times with letters of safe passage in her life to combine the details of several journeys he hasn't yet heard about into a story about this time. She is so convincing in her relation of the trip that she almost remembers having gone. Indeed, she wishes she had gone to Baneh rather than to the smelly bed at the caravanserai.

"If I'd had a son I would send him to Baneh, instead," he says just before sipping the last drop of tea. "Then you would be free to do so many other things."

"Like what, father?" she says. "Free to do what? Free to have time to cover my ears so I cannot hear the shelling of neighboring villages? Free to count the empty huts? Free to wail in the streets whenever news of the latest death on the front arrives?" She imagines that such an arrangement would leave her free to go out to the secret meeting places far into the hills and plan more assassinations, perhaps. "I prefer my trips to Baneh," she lies.

"I could send you to Tabriz for a proper upbringing," he answers. "A proper lady needs a proper upbringing."

"Tabriz? I hear the hospitals overflow with poisoned Kurds there. Refugees passing through have said that. Their skin gets burned, and the babies cling to the poisoned milk of their mothers' breasts. Nobody gets near a Kurd in Tabriz these days, for fear of contamination. Mr. Hamidpour's daughter has told of things that...."

“Your words are not as soft as usual, *aziz-am*,” he father says. “Did something bad happen to you on the way from Baneh?”

She can almost see the throat of the last soldier before her eyes. He did not shave for at least a week. He smelled of wine, or something even stronger. His neck was fat from his gluttony and her knife cut only with great effort.

“I’ve been brought up properly here,” she says. “The town needs a scribe, and you are the only one. I’d rather die of old age in a Kurdish village as a half-Kurd than be shipped off as a prize for some Azari rug seller. I can read a bit of Farsi, and you know that there are no others in the village who can. I will be able to take over as town scribe whenever.”

“A bit of Farsi,” he agrees. “That should be enough, really, except that there is so much to read. It’s all academics, anyway, *aziz-am*. You have to stay here to take care of me and your mother in our old age. I just wish sometimes, you know. Just wish. Ah, God! Back to work,” he says, standing to resume his own tasks.

She continues with the rice. Even after all this time, there seem to be as many pebbles as when she started. She realizes that the boy must have bought a cheaper bag of rice than he should have and kept the difference for himself. She will find another boy to go the next time his car comes to the caravanserai.

He is returning down the street. He does not seem to be fully aware of where he is going. He looks at her. His eyes are almost crossed. She is frightened; the rules are strict that the *Azadi* are not to look at one another in a public place. He has broken an ancient *Azadi* rule.

He then wanders down the pothole covered, rocky road, and she wants to call out to him. Her hands are shaking. She can feel the blood burning her skin.

“*Aziz-am*,” her father says. “*Marg-et chi-eh, Baba?*” he says, again in Farsi. “You are behaving badly today.”

What is your death? he has asked. She wants to tell him but steadies herself and continues at the rice and the

pebbles. Her heart is pounding so strongly that she feels she will vomit, but since she has not had time to eat breakfast, there is nothing for her to vomit up except tea.

“It is really nothing,” she finally says to him. “There are just too many pebbles in this rice. I am stupid and will have to remember to buy better rice next time I’m sent to Baneh.”

“*Alfleila wa leila,*” he says in Arabic after a long pause. He is not thinking as quickly as he used to.

“Father?”

“A thousand and one nights,” he explains it. “In this case, a thousand and one grains of sand in our rice. Sandy rice with turmeric. How your mother will box my ears tonight!”

His laughter is loud and she wants to put her hands over her ears to shut it out. Instead, she keeps her fingers to their task.

CHAPTER THREE

“Small portions, indeed,” he added to himself as soon as he could see her out on the street among her faceless peers. He knew she would not suspect his “perverse” words were loaded with a sober truth, since everyone in *Azadi* had something or other to hide—each hiding secrets more grave than the next—and it came with experience that the members accepted one another without questioning the words they exchanged during their infrequent meetings. Despite the usual *Azadi* protocol, however, he wanted her to know that the Kurds were, as he had said to her only moments before, as good as buried if he did not do something that very day.

He knew that the gas would come soon from Iraq and that it would be painful. It would be complete. Maybe one or two old men and women putting away jars of pickled eggplant and dried tomatoes in the cellar would be safe for a while, until they opened the cellar door to return to their life outside—or their death in this case. It didn’t help to piss in a rag and gag over it; that was another war that went by different rules. Mustard gas was civilized compared to what he knew these Kurds—women, old folks, and children in these days of endless war—would be facing from the sky.

When he knew he would not be associated with her by the prying curiosity of the others of the village, he left the room and descended the small staircase to the back door of the tiny caravanserai. He had paid for his room the night before, and had no baggage with him except his suitcase, as was always the scenario.

“At the Caravanserai”

You snooze at the caravanserai,
Licking your paws from night to Judgment Day,
But the blood of men is thicker than that,
And cannot quickly be washed clean that way....

High above Master you stretch in slumber as he sorts his things at the small table in front him. You will jump on his table when he is not looking up at you and sprawl out to scatter his things once more.

The front door of the caravanserai opens and you quickly decide that you want to stay inside where it is warm, since you can feel the briskness of the night air on your old, wet nose and it is not inviting. The Smelly One comes in and approaches Master with his hand outstretched.

“Jafar!” he calls out. Master grasps his hand and smiles the way he does with you after having tossed you some meat. “How are you, old man?”

“I am doing well, Abdul,” Master says. “It has been slow, but I’ve got two rooms let for the night. I can’t hope for more than that these days, you know.”

The Smelly One nods his head like a rat sniffing about for food scraps. “Travelers, then? Got some travelers bedding down for the night, do we? They usually go on to Baneh for the night.”

“I suppose so. Most of them *are* travelers. Not too many villagers come here, unless their roofs are rained out, or something. I don’t ask too many questions when they finally do wander into this place.”

“Yeah, not too many questions to scare them away, I guess. Don’t want to scare them away, hey? Not paying customers, anyway.”

“You got it. It’s certainly not like when *Kaak* Abadlou ran this place as a guest house to show everyone how *hospitable* he was to strangers.” Master sits down on his stool and offers the Smelly One a cup of some steaming tea.

The Smelly One accepts the tea and takes the stool at the other side of the table. “Uh huh! And unlike rich, dead old Abadlou—may God preserve his wretched gun-toting soul—you need a *tuman* or two here and again to keep yourself in food. And the cat. The cat’s got to eat something besides rats, too.”

“She *is* getting a bit old to be of much use as a ratter, that’s for sure. Eats mostly what I give her in her bowl and the odd bug now and again.”

“God, what animals will eat!”

“Must like your fish a whole lot, hey?”

“Not if I can help it! Your cat hasn’t been out of doors sniffing for fish for a couple of years now. I’m sure some of her spawn have been, though.”

Master looks at you and smiles. “She has had a lot of little ones, hasn’t she?”

“Yeah, and they’ll eat just about anything. Their own shit, if the mood takes them. Dogs are worse for that, though, as far as I can tell.” The Smelly One winces.

“Yup.”

“A game of *pah soor*?” he asks, as he always asks. “Boy, those must have been the days, though, hey? My father still talks of the *Kaak* now and again. He was an assistant to one or another of the... oh, I forget now, it’s been so long since he’s brought the old days up. Must of had something to do with fish, though, hey?”

“Yeah, this place must have been something to behold back then,” Master says, nodding his head vigorously as if he is sniffing about the air for something to eat.

“Now, how about a game, then? What say?” the Smelly One repeats.

Master nods his head and stands up to get the cards. Soon, he and the Smelly One are paying attention only to

what is on the face of the faded cards in their hands and those strewn upon the table. Again, the patched-up door swings open and the frigid air comes into the room, this time with a distinct and familiar smell of smoke about it.

“Good evening, sir,” Master says, putting down his cards and standing up. “Ah! It’s been a while since you’ve been through!”

“Yes, quite a spell!” the Tall One returns.

“Nice to see you again! How goes here with you?” He reaches out and shakes the Tall One’s hand. The Tall One has a suitcase with him. You have seen him before. He always smells of fresh air and cigarettes.

The Smelly One nods at the Tall One and the Tall One nods in return. “I’m good. And you and your friend?”

“I’m not bad myself. You want to join us in a game of rummy or even *pah soor*?” the Smelly One asks, holding out his cards.

“I only play for stakes,” the Tall One replies.

“Stakes?” the Smelly One asks, patting his pockets and then shrugging with a grin on his face.

“A room for one night, Jafar.” He digs into his pocket and puts some paper on the table. “I’ll pay in advance, old friend.” He then looks over at you and smiles widely while reaching up to pet under your chin. “Iran! Nice to see you’re still around! You playing cards with these two, then?”

“Yeah, she’s still with us, thank God. It’d be pretty lonely and quiet around here without her.”

“I didn’t know the cat’s name was *Iran*,” the Smelly One says, tapping his cards on the table and looking up at you on the ledge. “Oh, come on, how about just one friendly game with a couple of bored old Kurds?” he then asks the Tall One again.

“You ever seen a map of Iran?” Master asks the Smelly One.

“Nope. Don’t think I have. Don’t need a map to sell dried fish.”

“It wouldn’t mean much to you then. Iran is shaped like a cat from head to tail, you know, Abdul. Used to be a big map of Iran under where Shah’s picture used to be down in the common room, near the stove. When my father was still alive. I had the map buried with him.”

“And the portrait of Shah?” the Tall One asks with a wink of his eye.

“Burned it in the stove,” Master replies with a wink of his own. “It kept the place warm for about an hour. Stunk the place up a whole bit, though.”

The Smelly One opens his eyes wide and takes a closer look at you. “Iran? Like a blazing cat, no less? God, you’ve got to be kidding, Jafar, old man! And where are we on this cat? Somewhere near the bung hole, then?” The Smelly One slaps his side and starts to laugh so loudly that you bury your ears under your paws.

“Right on the collar, under its chin,” the Tall One says, stroking your chin. “East and West Azerbaijan form the head.” He taps your head. “Baluchistan is the tail.” He strokes your tail.

“And we’re at its neck, for God’s sake?”

“Right at the throat,” the Tall One says, dragging his finger across your neck, and you purr loudly for him. He takes the keys from Master that he has been handed. “Okay, just a quick round of friendly cards with you and Abdul here—you don’t mind if I just call you Abdul, do you?—since he’s so insistent.”

“Great!” the Smelly One says, pulling out the third chair and dealing more cards. “Just call me Abdul. My family name’s a long and ugly thing. Even I have trouble remembering it from time to time.”

The Tall One sits in the chair and looks at his cards, mumbling to himself. “Doesn’t look like I have much of a chance of winning a game against you two,” he says.

“What? We play fair,” the Smelly One says.

“My eyes are tired from driving all night,” the Tall One explains, rubbing his eyes. “It was so cold that I had to

drive with the car window up, so the cigarette smoke has taken its toll on them.”

“Just play one round,” the Smelly One insists, putting down one of his cards.

“Just one, then, Abdul,” he says as he sits with them.

Soon, the three men have finished and he stands to go to his room with the keys. When he has left the room his fresh smell stays behind a while.

“Iran! With God as your witness?”

“By the Twelve Saints!”

“By the Twelve Imams? Well I’ll be damned straight to hell,” the Smelly One says. “You learn something new every day, you do.” He makes a gesture to you that you are familiar with and you jump down, walk quickly over to him, and let him pet you with his fishy hands. The scent makes you hungry. “Shaped like you it is, then, Iran?”

“What, you think Iran was shaped like a fish or something?” Master laughs. “Anyway, that’s why I called her *Iran*.” He deals another round and the Smelly One soon ignores you for the game.

“Learn something new each day, Jafar,” the Smelly One says at last. “I’d be damned if I’d ever thought I’d learn something from a cat, though. A blazing cat, yet!”

You consider jumping up onto his lap, but decide to follow the Tall One’s scent until you arrive at his room. When you get there, it has already been closed, but you put your ear to the door and listen.

“Which side did the bullet enter?” This is the voice of the woman Master had given a key to earlier. She always smells of rice, and sometimes of blood. He is always with her when they are at the caravanserai, and she always comes to the room before he arrives.

“The right,” the Tall One replies. You hear the squeaking of a bed as if someone is sitting down on it.

None of this interests you, so you wander down the hallway a bit, sniffing about for bugs. You see that the Old One’s door is a tiny bit open and decide to enter his room.

The Old One is not familiar to you at all. He is sitting on his bed. As soon as you push the door open a bit more and come in, he hears the hinges squeak, turns his head toward you, and smiles.

“Cat! Nice to have a guest! Come in!” His face is very wrinkled, and wrinkles even more when he smiles at you. He stands, walks over to the door and closes it.

“You’ll have to wait a minute before I pet you, though, cat,” he says.

You jump up onto his bed where he was and curl up in the warmth. The Old One unrolls a rug, kneels on it, and begins praying as they mostly all do before going to sleep. When his prayers are over, he rolls up the rug again, puts it at the foot of the bed, and goes to his carry bag.

“I have something for you to eat here, my friend.” Soon, he produces dried fish and holds it out to you.

You grab it quickly in your teeth and begin chewing at it. After you are finished, you lick your paws and purr for him.

“I had a cat back home, you know.” He pets your neck, relieving you of a few fleas. “Nice creatures, cats.” He then sits on the bed beside you and starts chewing on a piece of the dried fish with his few remaining teeth. “I think a little boy came and killed it one day, because I never saw it after one *Nowruz* festival. Damned boys can be so thoughtless. Poor cat.”

You remember your frequent close calls with young boys during the years you used to venture out of the safety of the caravanserai more often.

“Anyway, cat, I was thinking when you came in. Thinking a lot. Thinking about my life.” You purr for him as he speaks to you and rocks back and forth. “How I don’t have a soul in the world to take me in, now that I’m old and weak, practically useless as a shepherd.” He stretches out his slender, wrinkled fingers and looks at them closely for a long time. “I’m rotting away right in front of my own eyes. I don’t have a nice comfortable little mat to lie down on or a nice fire to curl up in front of.”

You lick your paws as he talks to you. Others have talked to you about their secrets before. They seem to think you are listening to them.

"Nobody," he says as he stands again. He starts to pace about the room. "Here I am, a man old enough to remember the years before the fall of the Ottoman Empire, and instead of living out my last years with hardy sons taking care of me, I'm on my way on the back of a cursed stubborn mule to Marivan." He pats his buttocks and winces as if in pain. "A cursed mule! A man of my years!"

In reply, you purr for him a little more.

"I was *born* in Alout, you know, right on the border with Iraq. I'm not from wandering tribe or something, just shipped in to fill in the cracks like some of them were. *Born* there, do you understand?"

Still, you purr.

"Too much going on there in Alout these days. Didn't have any sons or daughters left—they've all been killed—" His eyes water over. "So I bartered little hut for how much? That damned mule and some trail supplies. I'll be down to Nanour and on to Marivan tomorrow morning. Nice town you have here, but—" He looks over each shoulder the way you do when you are looking for bugs to eat. "It's just like Alout. Everyone gone. Empty houses, cold stoves, and no one gathered around under the heat of the *korsi* blankets. No life, you know—no life.

"Well, there's one or two people in the street, judging by when I came into town, but Abadoun isn't much different than Alout. Well, not really Alout, a little gathering of huts just north of that, but you understand...."

He holds his mouth with his thickly callused hands and starts to chuckle to himself.

"No, I guess you don't, do you, cat? You don't really understand. Listen to me, talking to you like you understand what an old man ready to die had to say. Ho! Ho! Talking to a cat! Might as well be talking to the lice in that bed there."

He pats you a few times on your head, scratches behind your ears and goes over to wash his hands. When his hands are dry, he walks over to open his door and makes a movement with his hand that you know to mean he wants you to leave his room.

“Scoot, now, cat, scoot!” he says to you.

You get up off the bed, shake your body a bit to rid yourself of a few more fleas, arch your spine, and hop from the bed. Soon you are at the door and ready to leave.

“Nice talking to you, cat. Good night.” He closes the door behind you as you go down the hallway back to the Tall One’s door.

When you press your ear to the door again you hear the sounds they make when they are mating. You listen to this for a while, but it soon bores you and you return to Master and the Smelly One.

“Eleven!”

“I swear you cheat!” the Smelly One laughs at the Master.

“All that rotting fish in front of you all day rots your brain,” Master replies. He notices you have come back into the room and reaches his hand out to pet you. You run up to his hand and let him.

“Notice how the cats all stayed?” the Smelly One asks.

“Huh?”

“The cats. They’ve all stayed.”

The two of them do not talk for a while, and then Master finally says, “You’d think they’d be out in the hills, looking for food, or on to Baneh or Nanour, wouldn’t you?”

You purr as he pets you.

“But they stay.”

“Quite a few cats about.”

“Yeah, I’ve seen quite a few cats. I’m a fish monger, you know. Always worried about cats and other pests. Just as many cats trying for my fish today as there were when Abadoun was full of people.”

“Maybe if you left town, they’d follow the stench!” Master laughs.

“Smell better than this old cave!” the Smelly One returns with a closed fist waving about.

“Who stinks more, Iran?” Master asks, pointing first at himself, then at the Smelly One, as if you would answer his question.

They play cards some more and you decide to climb back to your ledge again and recline. Once you are up on the ledge, looking down at Master and the Smelly One playing cards again, you fall asleep quickly.

Morning comes and you are hungry. Master has placed a plate of stew scraps right in front of you and you hastily get it down. The Old One is putting his money in front of Master and Master is counting it.

“That’s really a beautiful cat you have, I tell you,” the Old One says, pointing up at you. “Really beautiful, by God.”

“Thank you,” Master says, looking back over his shoulder. “You have a cat yourself, sir?”

“Had one. Had a cat.”

“Just one? They tend to multiply. That one up there has given this town its share of kittens.”

“Just one. A male. I’m sure he sired his share of them, too, you know,” the Old One returned with a toothless grin in your direction.

“You know, a friend and I were talking last night about how all the cats are still in Abadoun, even after their owners have left.” Master returns the Old One’s change.

After some silence, the Old One looks up at you, his change still in his hand. “You know, cats are strange creatures,” the Old One finally says. “They sometimes do strange things by our standards. But then again, they don’t have our standards, since they know nothing of war, of suffering, of loss, of death, or of sorrow.”

“That’s for sure!” Master replies, bowing his head and rubbing his balding scalp with both hands. “They sure don’t

know what we human creatures go through, by God! For sure.”

“And so, they probably all figure, if they wait long enough—well—if they wait long enough, their owners will come back and feed them some scraps. Cats. They’re like that. No sense of things the way we do.”

Master thanks the Old One for his business and carries out the bags for him. He returns, scratching his head as if he, too, has fleas.

“Is that right, Iran?” he asks you, reaching up to pet you. You playfully bat at him with your paw. “Is that why they stay around here while we all disappear? You think they’re coming back?”

You cannot tell him. You lick your paws and purr as Master straightens out the things on his table one more time.

CHAPTER FIVE

He was soon weaving back and forth, dodging the bodies of the villagers who had come outside.

His keen nose was still used to the smell of the sour bedding he'd just left behind, but the air in the illegal gambling den in Baghdad had been much nastier and was still strong in his memory. As he passed a rough old bazaar keeper who sat squatting under the canopy of his nearly barren kiosk—one of the only things the tiny village did not seem in short supply of since the beginning of the war—he was reminded of the young soldier's face.

"I don't have the stakes on me," the soldier had said. The boy had already urinated in his uniform pants upon having the knife put to his throat and the smell of his urine would have been strong in the room were it not for the smoke.

“The Game”

Eleven comes, you win the hand again—
It seems you always win the hand, but then,
Bold Jack comes forth, foot soldier that he is,
And wipes all but Royalty off the plain.

“So, anyway, Nasrudin goes out into the cave—”

“Have we heard this yet?”

“It sounds familiar.... But then, they all sound familiar,
don’t they?”

“I swear you haven’t heard it from me!”

“Okay, go on—*out into the cave*—and then?”

“Well, of course, being a zealous reader of the Koran,
he wants to do some study, and, besides, nowhere in the
wording of the bet does it say he has to be bored.”

“Just no fire? Right. *Eleven*. My hand.”

“I still don’t get this ‘eleven’ thing.”

“Just no fire. That’s the bet. He lights a tiny candle to
read by, and prays all night long to God to let him not
freeze solid. You make elevens with one of your pip cards
and any number of the pips in the field, Hussein.”

“It *can* get cold up there....”

“How do you come up with those elevens and Jacks all
the time? And Jacks take the pips from the field, like he’s
been doing all night.”

“He nearly does, though, so they find him the next day
and carry him back to town, barely alive.”

“This is an Iranian game, and I’m an Iranian, that’s
how.”

“He nearly does what? What?”

“Freeze to death out in the cave. What else?”

“What about face cards? I mean, I get the eleven thing,
and the Jacks, but how do I get the Queen off the field?”

“So they find him nearly frozen, but he’s still alive, right? So, I suppose he’s won the bet, then? I mean, he went into the cave on a bet, right?”

“Speaking of bets, how about we double the stakes? Hussein, Hussein! You use another Queen to take a Queen. Face cards take their own. Put that Queen back—a King doesn’t take a Queen. Get it right before you start grabbing our cards.”

“But, our old friend Nasrudin is most definitely still alive, and some warm stew brings him to.”

“Funny as hell hearing an Arab tell a Persian tale. Sure, let’s double the stakes. Think you can handle the rules yet, Hussein, to start putting some money up yourself?”

“I don’t know if I know how to make a *soor*, or whatever you call those points.”

“Quit bragging about being Iranian. We’re at war, you know, and should just shoot you in your seat.”

“Now, now, you know the rules when we play cards—everyone’s a free agent. Just until we’re out the front door. You make *soors* by picking up the last card in the field with an eleven or a face card.”

“What about if I clear the field with a Jack? Do I get a *soor* if—”

“Just funny to hear you mispronounce Nasrudin, that’s all. Doubled. Your deal. No, you don’t. And not if you make the last pick up of the game, either.”

“So, after he’s on his feet again, Nasrudin declares himself winner of the bet. But a townsman approaches him and points out that the rescue party had found a burnt down candle in the cave with him.”

“Okay, I’ll put in my bet, then. I think I’ve got the hang of it now. I get the small pot if I get the *soor* and I get the big one when—”

“So?” Nasrudin asks.

“*If*, not *when*, Hussein. *If* you make the points.”

“The bet was *no fire*,’ the townsman insists. Hussein, you’re ruining my story. Anyway, he adds, ‘You said you

could survive without fire in the cave for a night. The candle disqualifies you, and you lose the bet.”

“I swear *I’ve* heard this one somewhere. Jack takes *all* pips. You see, Eqbal, the Iranian isn’t cheating; I won this one. And you see that, Hussein? I left the one King on the field and took only the pips with my Jack.”

“It’s strategy on his part to let an Iraqi win an ante or two.”

“Keep dealing the cards and shut up.”

“And, even if he’d cleared the field, no *soor*, because he cleared it with a Jack?”

“Right—no *soor*. Nasrudin complains, of course, but eventually just gives up. He gets an idea in his head, though, and goes up on a large rock and announces that everyone in the town is his guest at a feast, since he is a good loser.”

“Yeah, this is familiar, but anyway, go on. Two of clubs! Good show!”

“I haven’t heard this story yet, and you guys are cluttering it all up with your yapping.”

“Why is the two of clubs important?”

“And you Iranians are always spouting off about how you *own* Nasrudin. This deal is almost over, and we *did* say double, didn’t we?”

“Listen closely—the two of clubs is worth a point in the final count for the big pot. Now, back to Nasrudin—of course, when the night of the feast comes up, everyone shows up at Nasrudin’s home with hearty appetites. He sits them all down, has the minstrels play music for them, and time passes.”

“Even though the most clubs are also worth a point? I mean, you get the most clubs of the game, you get a point. Is the two still worth another point then?”

“If it’s the two of clubs, it’s worth a point no matter what. That’s right, we said *double*.”

“And more time passes. No food. The townspeople start to complain about the wait, calling him a terrible host.

“I can’t understand!” Nasrudin declares.

“He leads all the people into his kitchen, where they find a huge pot of soup, uncooked, sitting over one tiny candle like the one he had used to read the Koran in the cave.

“It has been sitting over the flame since yesterday!’ Nasrudin says. ‘You would think by now it would be cooked, would you not?’”

“Hah! Yeah, I’ve heard it, but it’s funny just the same!”

“And if this is like most of our Nasrudin tales, it is needless to say that the townspeople saw their folly and gave the bet to Nasrudin?”

“Exactly!”

“Nothing like a good Mullah Nasrudin yarn.”

“Time to count up, Iranian.”

“This is where a two is worth something—the count up?”

“Yes, that’s when it’s worth something, Hussein. Even you Iraqis can learn this game, given time. Aces, royalty, the most clubs, and the two of clubs. It appears that I have the most clubs.”

“You Persians must count on eleven fingers! This game is complicated! I think I’ll stick to flipping coins. I’ll keep more of my pay that way.”

“Damn! How does he do it?”

“Well, at least he let me win *one* little pot. Shrewd player.”

“Pay up time.”

“I don’t have the stakes on me.”

“Then I’ll have to cut your throat! I play fair cards. Wouldn’t want your stinking friends to think I didn’t collect on a stake.”

“Hey, he’s a bum if he doesn’t pay up, but we don’t stink that badly.”

“We do so. Ever take a good whiff? Now, now, Eqbal, you shouldn’t have doubled the stakes if you knew you weren’t good for it. That knife of his looks pretty nasty, and I for one am not going to be known as a dirty dealer.”

“Isn’t anyone going to shoot him or something?”

“Even Nasrudin knows that among gentlemen, a bet is a bet, Eqbal.”

“That’s a mighty sharp looking two of clubs he’s got there.”

“How could I ever play cards with you Iraqis again if it got to be known that I didn’t collect stakes? You don’t have money on you? So, what can you offer me instead?”

“I have information!”

“Okay. This is good. What is it?”

“It doesn’t go beyond this room, at least until you’re well out of Baghdad.”

“We’ll turn a deaf ear, Eqbal, since you *do* owe him half a day’s pay. Boys, let’s all just go have another drink in the other room.... Come on Hussein. There are more rules to playing cards than meet the eye.”

“Bring more money next time, Eqbal, or don’t make stupid wagers.”

“So, what’s the big news? I’ve heard a lot of things in my business, so it’ll take quite a bit to convince me not to cut you.”

“Well—I’d be shot for telling you this—I know the date and time a certain town in Iran is going to be hit with a gas attack.”

“And? I don’t have all day, Eqbal.”

“You won’t kill me if I tell you, right? You won’t cut me? The bet is even?”

“Something like that. And I won’t tell your friends in there that you pissed your pants. I’m just being fair. You play, you pay.”

“On the border, in Kurdistan Province. Gassed.”

“What town? Nanour? Alout?”

“No, smaller than those. Abadoun. A small town. I never heard of it until—”

“*Abadoun*? You sure about that name, Eqbal?”

“You know it? It important to you?”

“When? Never you mind about what it means to me. When?”

“One week from now, to the day, just after the noon call to prayer. God preserve me—I’m a traitor for the stakes in a stupid Persian card game.”

“God will only preserve you if you’re not a liar as well as a drunk, gambling louse. How do I know your information is correct? It’s worth nothing to me if it isn’t, you know. Soldiers gossip, and the gossip isn’t always based on—”

“I’ll be one of the troops who go in after the low flying jet drops the canisters of gas. It’s in the mountains, so they’ll have cover.”

“Who’ll have cover, the jet and the troops? Certainly the Kurds won’t. I’ll take your word for it.”

“Don’t tell anyone what I said or I’m—”

“As good as shot for treason. Or worse. I know. But how about your friends in there? Won’t they suspect that *this* is what you’ve had to say?”

“No. They’re not in on it at all. I’ve been pulled from their troop for this one, since I have mountain experience.”

“Mountain experience? You mean they’ve used you to clean up on attacks against Iraqi Kurds?”

“Let’s just say that I’ve got *mountain* experience and they’re sending me in on this one. As for my friends out there, they play by the rules. We’re all old friends.”

“Okay, Eqbal, let’s shake hands and part on good terms. You’ve paid what you owed me.”

“I swear with Abraham’s mother as my witness I ought to give up gambling altogether, Iranian.”

“Just until I’m back from Iran on my next run, hey?”

“Hey! One of these times I’m going to win you big! Can’t give up gambling until then, you know.”

“Wonderful! It’s good to see you two are friends again.”

“Another Nasrudin story? How about another *friendly* game? No money involved? At least until Hussein here gets all the rules down. Then we can start teaching him some strategy.”

“I only play for stakes!”

“Take the Iranian seriously! He plays for stakes!”

“I could use another glass of beer, though.”

“It’s too bad wars don’t work like card games. Things would be so much simpler.”

“Don’t they? What *do* you win when you win, and what *do* you lose when you lose, Hussein?”

CHAPTER SEVEN

“Okay. This is good. What is it?”

The soldier named Eqbal had only owed him the equivalent of about half a day’s pay, and as payment for that minor debt, he was informed that Abadoun would be gassed just after the cry of the noon muezzin.

Unless some act of his changed the fate the Iraqis had in store for them, all those still clinging to the place of their birth would be bent toward Mecca, wailing and yelling out Sunni appeals to God when the poisoned Iraqi manna would come down from the heavens. Some would get the chance to look up and then their faithful eyes would burn right out of their sockets. Only the few old men and women in the cellars with their jars of pickled eggplant would not die on their knees, but they would all eventually die nonetheless.

“Hey! You, there!” someone shouted at him from amidst the moving crowd.

The cry was in Farsi—was it an Islamic Revolutionary Guard? If it was, should he bother running, only to be shot at as he skipped to and fro through the mass of bodies? If they stuck him in a dark cellar at the mullah’s house for the day until they knew what to do with him, he would certainly die with the rest of them. If they shot him for fleeing, and he didn’t live to warn them, his panic would surely sign the death certificate of the villagers. He waited for another call, to see if whoever it was indeed was hailing him and not someone else.

“I said you! Stop!” came the cry again, this time somewhat more loudly and urgently.

The people in the crowd moved about enough so that saw who it was now who was calling out. It was a *Pasdar*.

The semi-automatic rifle looked ready to defend all of the tenets of Islam at a moment's whim and fury.

"Yes? How may I help you?" he asked.

The Revolutionary Guard approached him boldly, something quite unusual for a solitary guard to do to someone in the middle of what must have seemed like hostile territory. He then noticed that a truck full of eleven other guards was not far behind the man. They appeared to be regular army, soldiers obligated to follow the infallible and often stubborn orders of the *Pasdar*. The shoppers split to either side of the vehicle to let it through.

He had trained himself over the span of his years of covert activities to sweat not even a single bead in such situations, but he wondered if they could hear his untrained, pounding heart. He knew his training would have to survive the next few moments; it would be certain disaster if his forehead gave away his motives in a bath of salty confession. The sound of the *Pasdar*'s boots on the hardened earth gave him something to focus on and he was soon steely calm again and it came back to him that he had used his *Tehrani* accent.

"Are you from here?" the Guard asked. He now saw that the Guard was barely old enough to be called a man—his skin was smooth, closely shaven, like that of a pre-pubescent boy or even a girl. They always had their hand ready on the trigger, so that was not evidence enough of danger to try to run into the crowd and take cover behind an open door or fat old man. The Guard's age was not a factor in anything, either, since young or old, the rifle would shoot as straight as any man's, given the same training and determination to kill for Ayatollah's Islam.

“Soldier’s Sisters”

Just yesterday, the muezzin cried out,
Today, it is the mothers who will shout,
Tomorrow, soldiers’ sisters rend their shawls—
Iran’s sorrow will fall and rise throughout.

“Who is she?”

Photograph of veiled woman in shivering hand of the
Islamic Revolutionary Guard. Quick glance over to the
direction of the voice. His reply: “My sister.”

Bowing of heads among the other eleven.

Understanding without words. Noise from stones under the
wheels of the vehicle piercing everyone’s ears. Bouncing
and bowing. Memories of other sisters and fiancées. Some
prayers and supplications.

“She’s getting married this spring.”

Nods and smiles. Hands on rifles, hands holding scarves
to young, fearful faces. Bouncing bodies, close together.
Gasps from the bouncing and prayers for the betrothed.

“Married. That’s *good*. My sister will be happy with
him. He’s a good man.” *Pasdar’s* words. Listening ears.

“Married to a good man. Yeah, that’s wonderful.”

Words said to please *Pasdar’s* ears.

Memories of his sister jumping about with the jerking of
the bench. Memories of warmer days at the edges of
Teheran. Memories of daylight and of smiling, uncovered
faces. Memories of candies shipped fresh from Esfahan
especially for *Nouruz* festivals and of sweet, sticky *zulia*
at other weddings.

“It’s pretty dark out.” Scared words from a boy of
sixteen. A boy with no lover, sister, or friend back home to
sweeten the sourness and the fear and the cold. Words from
a scared child not expecting to make it to Baneh alive.

“It will be light soon.” *Pasdar*’s words again, to comfort someone not much younger than himself.

“Yeah, soon, *ensh-Allah*.”

Words of faith from the back of the vehicle: “Why ‘*ensh-Allah*,’ my friend? God always wills the sun to rise. We can be certain it will rise. Certain. We just may not be there to see it. That’s the ‘*God-Willing*’ part.”

“And, God willing, when will we be in Baneh?” Words from a soldier passing timeworn prayer beads one at a time along their string.

“Just after we pass through the next town. Not long after that, I’d say.”

“And which town is that?”

“Used to be called Pahlavidezh,” in reply. “Don’t know what it’s called these days. The Revolution changed the names more quickly than the mapmakers could keep up with.”

Time passing. Road twisting. Bodies pressing one against the other. The town once called Pahlavidezh minutes ago. More lights.

“What’s this town? We at Baneh yet?”

Pasdar’s words: “It’s not on my map. These tiny Kurdish towns—if you can call them ‘towns’—can come at you from out of nowhere.”

“Out of nowhere. Just like the Kurds themselves.” Laughing. Fear in the laughter. “We’d better keep our backs covered and our heads bent, or we’re likely to be shot at. I heard about a nasty ambush around here not long ago.”

“That was on the Iraqi side of things,” from someone knowledgeable.

“They’re all Kurds, on either side of the blasted border. Ambush there, here, it’s all the same. Dead somebodies. Dead soldiers. Blasted Kurds.”

“They come out of the hills in the dark.” The young man again, his shaking hands rubbing the cold steel of his rifle.

Small road sign swinging in the wind from the end of a bent stick. Flashlight shining at it from *Pasdar's* hand.

"*Abadoun*. Never heard of it. Who speaks Kurdish here?"

No reply from any of the regular soldiers.

"Then, let's hope one of them speaks Farsi."

"Or French," from one of the older men. "I can get by in French."

"Not a likely proposition up here in bloody no-man's land, you old bugger."

Quickly out of the driver's mouth: "No cussing in front of the *Pasdar*!"

"Well, what kind of fuck up thinks these bastards are going to speak any bloody French, *goh-e-sag*!" A raised, defiant fist.

Swift chastisement from the Revolutionary Guard: "We're all God's soldiers, men. I know you're under a lot of stress, but keep your tongues clean for *namaz*, will you?"

"*Mazarat mikha'am*," from the offender.

"Don't worry about it," from the French speaker. A pat on the shoulder from across the truck.

Stopped in the middle of the main street. Silence. No one about. *Pasdar's* boots hitting stones. Steps echoing into the hills and the cold air. Twelve fingers ready on twelve triggers. Glances between comrades. Glances into shut up windows. Glances into the menacing hills above.

"They could be waiting for us." Young man's words again, whispered.

"They most likely are, the dogs."

Hand pounding at door. Long silence. Cold air creeping down into his collar. Hand up to pull the scarf over the opening. Fingers rubbing neck to bring warmth back into it.

Door opening slowly. Woman's eyes peering out at him. Veil high up on face, covering everything but the peering eyes and the thick brows.

Pasdar's words: "Do you speak Farsi?"

Nothing in return but a stream of syllables meaningless to him.

"Baneh. I want Baneh."

Long string of more noise in return.

“Damn it! I want Baneh. *Ba-neh*.”

Gun waving back and forth before the woman’s face. Temperature rising from anger and hopelessness. Door closing after minutes of muttering and useless repetition of the word *Baneh*.

“We’ll wait until the town is awake and find a Farsi speaker. Or a French speaker. Hah, neither is very likely up here in the mountains. We’ll wait anyway.” *Pasdar*’s order. Silence in return. Twelve cold bodies huddling together in the truck. Twelve fingers almost freezing to the triggers.

Young boy’s words: “When do we get to fight?”

Another’s words: “You’ve never fought before?”

Heads bowing, whispered prayers. Prayer beads clicking on the string.

“We’ll wait in Baneh until we get orders to go east and join the others in Saqqez.”

“All these town names.” Older, experienced man. “In all my seventeen years in one army or another I’ve never heard of some of them.”

Another: “Kurdistan. We would be better to give it to Iraq and let Hundred-Trap Hussein deal with the Alouts and the Abadouns.”

“Hah! Hundred-Trap. I’ve always loved that—”

Pasdar: “Iranian soil is Iranian soil, whether it’s Teheran, Shiraz, Mashad, Qom, or—Abadoun.” Silence following his words. Movements. Hands rubbing together, hands into pockets, fingers stroking triggers to keep from freezing to the metal.

The older soldier: “Spoken like a true *Pasdar*! And when we beat old *Sadd Daam* into the earth at Baghdad, you can have Abadoun. All of Kurdistan Province if you want it.”

Laughter. Even the *Pasdar*’s laughter. Clouds of water forming in the air before the faces of those laughing, attached to the open mouths spitting them forth like grasping ghosts.

“Cold as Gehenna up here in the hills. How I ache for Yazd. I ache for the smell of cotton in the blast-furnace of hot wind.” Words from someone silent since leaving Marivan.

“What, we don’t smell pretty enough for you?” from the older, battered soldier.

“Even the dust on the ground smells sweet in Yazd. Even a stinking corpse would smell sweet in Yazd about now.”

“I live for Esfahan.” Another’s words mixing in with the conversation.

A familiar play on words from the man beside the nostalgic *Esfahani*: “Esfahan, *nesf-e-jehan*.”

“Yes. Half the world *is* Esfahan, were it not for *Teheran*.”

“We’ve a poet in our midst.”

“Heh, heh. I’ve written a quatrain or two in the Iraqis with this!” A swift jerk of the gun.

“Esfahan nothing, I say! Give me Yazd! Oh, we had fun hunting down the Zoroastrian’s dogs and cutting off their tails when we were boys. Where else can you find so many dog lovers to push around than in Yazd, hey?”

“You have a woman back in Yazd, then, *Yazdi*?”

Pasdar’s ears twitching from the cold and the mention of a woman. Hand fumbling with the picture of his sister.

“I have a wife and three sons. And a daughter. We had another daughter, but—”

Silence everywhere. Faces pointing down to the wooden floor of the truck.

Pasdar’s reply: “But?”

“She was young and impressionable. Her heart was taken by a charming anti-Shah activist. She was sent to ‘school’ for reeducation is what they told us at first. SAVAK. Evin, you know.”

Again, silence and whispered prayers.

“Reeducation? How old could your oldest—”

“Fourteen. Old enough to be charmed by a charming— Well, you get the idea. Old enough.”

“Yeah, old enough, then.” A slap on the back from the older soldier. An unspoken condolence for a missing enemy of the old regime daughter.

“If we die, they’ll tell your kin that you died well. And they’ll get a good pension from the Foundation.” The younger one again.

The older one: “Who will they tell if you die, boy?”

“I’m an orphan.”

Silence and prayers for a boy martyr leaving no mourners.

“That’s enough of this kind of talk. Let’s keep our mind on God’s mission for us, which, for the time being, is finding Baneh.” *Pasdar’s* orders. Silence without any prayers. Obedience. Fingers frozen to triggers once more. Straight backs. “But, since we’re on the point, you regular army have a good pension on your heads. My Islamic Revolutionary Guard pension is less than regular army. *We* are in this for the Glory of God and the Imams, men. Remember that.” Recitation of words heard from another of his kind.

People wandering about everywhere, avoiding the truck. Too many to single out a Farsi speaker. Foreign words being spoken left and right and all about him.

His cry: “Hey! You, there!” Hope in him of finding someone understanding Farsi enough to turn around and look at him. No response. Another try: “I said you! Stop!” Hand ready on the trigger. Fear pounding in his heart. Images of his sister floating about the pool of fear. Images of the *Yazdi’s* daughter being tortured in prison for having taken a stance against Shah. Cold biting at his nose, freezing back into his throat.

A man not dressed like the other Kurds turning, saying: “Yes? How may I help you?”

Finger tighter on the trigger. The sound of his heart pounding in his ears, like the drums of his favorite Dervish music. Feet under him pulling him through the crowd toward the man. Face frozen in look of the authority of his station. Truck following behind him, ready to assist him.

Villagers moving away from the truck. Foreign words almost freezing solid in the puffs of steam foaming forth in front of the faces of the many Kurds about the place.

Pasdar's question: "Are you from here?"

Man's reply, strong with a familiar *Tehrani* accent: "No, sir, I am not from here. I am from Teheran. I'm on business."

"Oh, that might not be good." Turning to the truck, saying, "Not one of them," hearing, "Try anyway!" in reply. Hand always ready to shoot. "How long have you been around here?"

Welcomed reply: "I know the town well. I've been here quite a few times in the past."

Blood again in his face. "Good! You know where we can find a good road out of this place? It's all crossroads and twisted intersections, and our map doesn't have any detail. We're headed for Baneh. These dirty Kurds can't speak Farsi, or something. They don't understand us." Being brave, pointing rifle at a woman in the crowd and making a gesture at the trigger. "That, they'd understand. They would learn Farsi in Evin Prison." Laughter from all except one of the comrades in the truck. Blood again flowing in his hands and face. Images of the *Yazdi's* daughter fading from the forefront of his mind.

Out of Abadoun and on to Baneh. Abadoun long gone. *Pasdar* looking over at the *Yazdi*, saying: "Listen, I'm sorry."

"Sorry, sir?"

"About mentioning Evin. You know, your daughter."

"Well, I admit I didn't laugh with the rest when you mentioned Evin." Understanding looks between the two men.

"You sure had that bastard pissing his pants!" from the older soldier. Slaps on backs and laughter.

"You know, he sure didn't look Kurdish to me."

Explanation for the young boy from the *Pasdar*: "A businessman from Teheran."

“Out near the border?” from the older man. “A businessman? What’s he selling? Guns to rebels, maybe?”

Looks back and forth between the men. Fingers again on triggers.

Agreement from someone else: “In Abadoun of all places? A businessman from Teheran? Sounds pretty stupid.”

“Yeah, but who has time to start checking papers out in the middle of the street, surrounded by all those bloody Kurds? It’s cold and we’re on our way to Baneh and then on to Saqqez.”

From the experienced one: “You’d think you *Pasdaran* would be a little more careful, by God. I say we take the time to go back and give him the once over, at the very least.”

From the driver: “Listen, sir, maybe we ought to turn back and check that one out. There have been reports of covert activity on the border, you know.”

Long period of silence disturbed only by the grinding of rocks under the wheels of the truck. Finally a statement: “Listen, all of you, I had no reason to start questioning him, really. As I see it, men, we have God’s mission laid out for us and as I’ve already said, for the time being, His mission for us is to get to Baneh and then on to Saqqez to join our brothers in arms. If I’d started poking on about papers out in the middle of hostile territory, we might have all been shot in the heads and backs from the roof tops or something. He was just a businessman. And we’ll be in Baneh soon enough. I’ll send a regular army unit from there to give him the ‘once over.’”

Silence. Obeying orders. Bouncing and praying. Loud cracking bursts and sudden motion in circles. Legs and arms all interwoven.

From the driver: “A tire’s been shot out!”

Dread. Fear. Panic. Noise.

“Sir? Orders?”

“Return fire!” from the young one.

“Kurds!” from the older soldier. Rifles aimed at the hills, safeties off, ready to kill.

“Can’t see ’em!” from the driver.

Pasdar’s order: “Shoot at will! To kill!”

Random shots back and forth. Screaming soldier at his side, hit in the left shoulder, pouring out blood and oaths.

Pasdar to driver: “Can we get out of here?”

“Won’t turn over.”

Sound of rocks and road beneath *Pasdar’s* boots on side of truck opposite the hills and Kurds. Quick steps to the front of the truck. Finger on trigger, rifle up, firing over the front end of the truck. Echoes of bullets hitting only stone.

Pain of bullet tearing into his neck, knocking him off his feet. Spinning. Warmth of his blood pouring from him and down his collar. Desperation in his actions. Hands digging in his shirt for the photograph.

Screaming and joyousness from the young one: “I got one! My first kill! God be praised—I killed one of the Kurds!”

Fingers almost tearing the photograph. Eyes wanting to close, ears wanting to close. Head back on the stones of the road. Pain disappearing. Light disappearing.

“Sir?” coming from the driver. “Sir? Oh my God! Two men to help me!”

Blackness approaching. Photograph pressed to his bloody lips for a last kiss from sister. Nineteen-year-old *Pasdar*, defender of the faith.

And in Teheran, a Shi’ite sister rending her shawl.

CHAPTER NINE

He suddenly wished he had replied in Kurdish. Judging by the Guard's accent, he knew that he was pure *Tehrani* stock and would not have been able to converse in anything other than Farsi—a reply in Kurdish would have left him dumb and looking for another to harass. Why was he being asked if he was from Abadoun? He certainly didn't dress like a Kurd, and anyone even basically familiar with the area could have guessed that he was not a local. The Kurds could not wear their traditional national dress to its fullest extent, but even in times of war, they managed to rise above the oppression and look like Kurds.

"No, sir, I am not from here," he replied. Maybe he could establish some type of rapport? But then again, the people of Teheran were all a bastardized mix of refugees and orphans these days, so he might make a joke about a part of Iran in particular disfavor with the Teheran crowd these days only to discover that this boy was born there. "I am from Teheran. I'm on business." Would he ask for proof? If so, he knew he didn't have a scrap of paper on him with an official signature on it—his forgeries were all in his car, and even those conflicted with one another upon close scrutiny. A paperless citizen was not unheard of even in these days of war with Iraq, but it would be most difficult to explain at gunpoint out in the middle of a cluttered market square with nowhere to run that businessmen have a way of slipping through bureaucratic cracks in the daily maintenance of their particular branch of wartime commerce.

"Oh, that might not be good" the guard returned. He turned to the soldiers and mumbled something, and when one of them mumbled something equally cryptic in return,

he turned back to him and said, "How long have you been around here?"

He tried to determine what exactly it was he was being asked, since he knew the *Pasdar* would not have taken the time to ask if he hadn't a purpose in doing so; the Sunni Kurds were not known to be sympathetic to the Shi'ite causes of the *Pasdaran*. Finally, he decided that the soldiers were probably trying to get directions out of the village or to the mullah's house. "I know the town well," he said. "I've been here quite a few times in the past."

The guard's face lit up at this. "Good! You know where we can find a good road out of this place? It's all crossroads and twisted intersections, and our map doesn't have any detail. We're headed for Baneh. These dirty Kurds can't speak Farsi, or something. They don't understand us." He pointed his rifle at a woman in the crowd and pretended to shoot. "That, they'd understand. They would learn Farsi in Evin Prison."

It then became clear to him that the Guard had yelled out just to see who flinched, since that would immediately give away the Farsi speaker. He had long ago trained himself not to flinch and was angry that his training had been obscured by the mist of what he knew would be the village's fate. He quickly gave the guard instructions and the truck was soon on its way to Baneh with its cargo of soldiers.

"If only you had stayed stuck here until just after prayer, you would have found victory in *jihad* so much sooner," he said to himself as he wandered past the shops. He felt an unusual heaviness as he passed the shop where she worked, unlike anything he had ever felt when passing there before. She would be there, he knew, getting things ready for the day, listening to her father, plucking the stray pebbles from the dinner rice. He knew she would see him, from under her heavy veil, but he did not have the benefit of a veil, and could not look her way. As he struggled to lift his cumbersome legs one step at a time over the broken surface

of the tilted road, a small boy ran out into the street. Not far behind the boy ran a robust old man with a heavy cane.

“Get that boy!” the old man called out to him and the rest of the crowd. He knew that at the bazaar the best thing to do was not to stand out and have a finger pointed at him as a liberal who would let a thief run past him, so he grappled the boy and held him solidly.

“The devil is in that boy!” the old man hollered as he grew closer. “He stole a tomato from my kiosk. Who here is brave enough to claim him as their son? I say the man’s father is a dog!” the shop keeper challenged as he yanked the boy from him. “The little thief!”

No one called out to claim the boy, and after a long period of silence, the boy opened up his shirt and produced a large tomato for the old man. The look he gave the man was obviously not one of contempt.

“What shall I do with him?” the old man asked him.

“One Tomato”

I saw a boy throwing stones in the street,
They rolled down the blood-stained road to the beat
Of soldiers' boots. I knew each rock was aimed
Not at the road, but at those soldiers' feet.

Two nights ago my family ate with Mr. Farzad Rezai, assistant to Mullah Aziz. He ate our rice, *saji* bread, and yogurt as gladly as any other guest we've ever had and he parted with as many smiles and compliments as any other of our other guests. That is to say, the Shahpouri family's hospitality was enough for him the day before yesterday.

I am young, but I am neither stupid nor am I lowborn, so despite my rash actions at the tomato stand later into the morning, and the beating I received for stealing the tomato, there is no reason to suppose that I am just a teahouse entertainer with a tall tale to tell. My father is the son of an Azari khan, robbed by the Pahlavis of his land and title. He has always taken great care to educate me himself in the ways befitting a future khan, should the title ever be restored to the family. Now we live in the small town of Abadoun, but my grandfather used to oversee thirty towns in Azerbaijan far larger than it, and everyone who lived in those towns. Whereas he owned thirty towns, I have only thirty *tuman*.

My mother, my young sister Donyazad, and I were held at gunpoint by masked bandits as they emptied our small house of everything we owned.

“Don't take the photographs!” my mother yelled at them, waving her fist.

“And why not?” the masked man asked. He wasn't wearing the clothing of a Kurd.

Mother knew that the photographs were our only claim to our heritage. Father with his father, old Khan Shahpouri, side by side. She would not, however, tell him this, and I knew it. She was too proud to have to beg to defend her husband's claim.

"My father is a khan!" I shouted at the man, not too proud myself.

"A khan!" the bandit howled. His accomplices had already almost finished their work. "And I suppose he," he said, pointing at my father, unconscious on the floor, "is also heir to Shah?" The others laughed with him.

I spit at him. At least if he was a Muslim, he wouldn't be able to beg forgiveness for his actions until he had a good wash.

He pointed his rifle straight at me and readied his finger to shoot. It was then that I noticed that he was wearing my grandmother's ring. He must have put it on while searching through our belongings.

"Shoot me!" I told him. "I'd rather die than live to remember that you wore my grandmother's ring!"

"I don't shoot brave little khans," he said. He put down the rifle, turned, and followed his accomplices out the front door. I tried to chase him to the door, but my mother grabbed me first, and held me in place. It was soon over, and we were all sobbing, huddled together, trying to make sense of the theft. Most everything had been taken, even our rugs from Tabriz. Since our house was enclosed by a wall of mortar and stone, I knew we were alone and unseen.

"Go get Rezai!" my mother howled. "We've been robbed! Mullah will have to know!"

I ran out of the house, looking around for signs of the bandits. There were none, so I rushed over the loose stones of the walkway that led down to Mr. Rezai's tiny shack. I pounded on the shaky door for some time before his servant came and opened it.

"Beg pardon," I panted, "I'm looking for Mr. Rezai."

“He’s asleep,” the Arab servant, an old hag who was nearly blind, returned.

“We’ve been robbed,” I explained. “Bandits. Four bandits.”

“Your name?” she asked.

“Shahpouri,” I answered her. “I am Mostafa. Mr. Rezai knows us. Please have him come.”

I was soon home again. Father was awake, rubbing his head, moaning. Mother was tending to his wound. Donyazad was huddled in the corner of the main room that had once held the chest full of photographs, sobbing. The thieves had even stolen our *korsi* blanket, so the round table in the middle of the room had nothing covering it, nothing for us to gather under to keep us from the bitter cold of autumn. The coals in the *korsi* pit glowed as hot as the Hell I knew those men would be going to.

“Did they leave anything?” Father asked.

“Nothing at all,” Mother returned. “They’ll burn in Hell for this. God has a special place in Hell for them. A very hot place.”

“The photographs?” Father added, still rubbing his head.

“Gone,” Mother sighed.

“We must get them back,” he insisted.

I sat on the dusty floor, which now was cold and dirty without a rug, and put my feet straight out in front of me. “I tried to fight them,” I said.

“He did,” Mother said. “We have a brave son, Shahpouri. The leader of these crooks spared his life because he was brave.”

My father looked at me with a smile. “I’ve always known that. He’s a khan.”

“Not without those photos,” I sighed.

“Ah! Be quiet! Don’t say that!” he scolded me, waving a fist at me.

We all sat as close to the *korsi* as we could get, but without the blanket over it to huddle under, we were all

shivering badly by the time Farzad Rezai arrived at our door an hour or so later.

“What seems to be the matter?” he asked us, a distant, formal tone in his voice. He was fully dressed, all in black, with a gray sash around his waist that had a pipe stuffed in it, and he was carrying the Koran with him.

“We’ve been robbed,” my father explained, stretching his arms out and pointing to our empty room.

“Robbed?” he said. He looked around the empty house a while. “I see you have your cooking utensils, Mrs. Shahpouri. What have they stolen?”

“Everything!” she howled. “Everything!”

“Now, come on,” he chastised my mother, “stop the howling, woman. What had you to steal? You’re a poor family. I can’t imagine what you had here worth stealing.”

My father sat up, pointing at a now empty corner that had once held a wooden chest full of memories. “They stole my trunk, for one. It was very—”

“A chest? I suppose you would want me to believe it was inlaid, or something?”

My ears began to sting with disbelief. Mr. Rezai had just eaten at our house and couldn’t remember the chest?

“Then where is our *korsi* blanket?” I finally burst out.

“You’ve seen what we have,” I said. “You were here for dinner two—”

“Be quiet, you vulgar little dog,” he snapped. “I don’t have any reason to think you were robbed. Pray to God for some honesty and stop lying. Next time you come howling to my door in the dead of night, pray have a real complaint.”

“Mr. Rezai, you know—”

“Are you familiar with the story of Mullah Nasrudin and the two bandits?” he asked me.

I nodded no.

“Mullah Nasrudin heard someone in his home, became frightened, and hid in a great clay pot usually used for rice. The two burglars eventually came upon the pot and opened it.

“What are you doing in there?” one of the burglars asked Mullah.

“Hiding.”

“From us?” asked the other. “We’re bandits, not murderers. No need to hide from us! Pray, come out!”

“I’m ashamed to be seen in a house that has so little worth your efforts!” Mullah returned.”

Farzad Rezai was soon gone. He did not close what was left of our broken door behind him.

“He’s been bribed!” my father snapped.

“Listen how he uses Mullah Nasrudin as if he were quoting the precedents of Hadith,” my mother said, clenching her fists. “What a jackass!”

“Bribed by the bandits before he arrived here. I can still smell the stink of his corruption in the room.”

“Father?”

“You know what I mean. The real world,” Father explained, “is not fair. The bandits must have paid him to side with them on this. It’s in his best interest to ignore us. We can’t pay him as much as they can, now that we’ve been robbed.”

“But—”

“Mostafa, forget it. We’re just going to have to—”

“But the photo—”

“Mostafa,” my father repeated.

I went silent. I’d never before seen my father beaten down by anyone. I knew he was right, though—we had nothing to bribe Rezai with as valuable as what the bandits must have given him on the road to our house. After all, they now had everything of value we’d ever owned. I went to my bed, which was a mess of torn blankets, and tried to sleep.

Of course, I couldn’t fall asleep. When the day was light enough, I left the house and wandered the street along the creek down near the bazaar, trying to make sense of Mr. Rezai’s actions. I knew that now that he was old and feeble, Mullah Aziz wouldn’t act against the bandits without his assistant’s support on the matter.

I was soon passing the bazaar. I saw a pile of tomatoes and it occurred to me that the world was without justice. We did not have enough money to buy even one tomato now, and Mr. Rezai was probably walking around town with my grandmother's ring in his pocket, or, even worse, boldly on his finger—his great prize.

The tomato stand was as likely a target as any. I was fuming mad, and uninterested in anything other than growing old and strong enough to exact my revenge on Mr. Rezai for betraying my family. It was then that I grabbed a large, dried tomato from the pile without thinking.

It occurred to me to run, so I did. My feet carried me quickly down the main street and around a corner. I didn't look behind me to see who was pursuing me, but I could hear the commotion all about me. I took a bite from the tomato as I ran and then stuffed it into my shirt. Soon, I bolted down a small alley and out into another part of the bazaar.

"Get that boy!" someone screamed.

Someone from the crowd, a man dressed like the city people who sometimes passed through, grabbed me and held on to me so tightly that I could not struggle free.

"The devil is in that boy!" screamed the voice again. I soon saw that it belonged to an old man carrying a cane. "The devil is in that boy!" the old man howled as he came. He didn't sound all too different than my mother had after the robbery at our home. "He stole a tomato from my display. Who here is brave enough to claim his son? The man's father's a dog!"

I wanted to yell at him, "I'm a khan! A khan, you filthy old man!" but I remembered the reward that kind of pride had gotten me with the bandit, so I remained silent.

The old man yanked me from the city man who had caught me by the arm. "The little thief!" he growled.

I opened my shirt and gave the tomato to the old man. I hadn't really meant any harm by stealing it. I'd been angry, that was all.

“What shall I do with him?” the old man asked the man who had caught me.

“How much is this tomato worth to you?” the other asked in reply.

“If every dirty little boy with a bit of hunger in him were to steal just one of my tomatoes,” the old man said, “I would not eat myself, and the good people here would have nowhere else to get their own. Were it my choice, I’d lash him once for every tomato in the pile he stole it from. This is war time, a time when people go hungry for lack of food.”

I wanted to say, “What about the Shahpouri family who will go hungry because they cannot even buy a dried sugar beet now?” but I held my tongue. I started to shake. The thought of one lash from the cane made me ill. I could hear people in the crowd either supporting his threat or saying it was too much. I looked about for my father, but knew I wouldn’t find him in the crowd, since he would still be at home, having his head tended to by mother. He would have claimed me had he been among them, though. I wanted to be out of the old man’s hands so badly that I couldn’t even feel his grip on my arm any longer.

“Why not send him up to the mullah and have him decide?” an old lady in the crowd asked.

Her voice sounded like someone my family knew. How could someone who *knew* me send me up to the mullah for punishment? Wasn’t this the same mullah who sent off her sons to be slaughtered?

“Listen, I want to punish the boy, not have him scarred for life. God Himself is merciful—just one lash for every tomato in the pile will be enough.”

Again, the thought of even one lash made me shudder. I had seen the pile—the pile with more than twenty tomatoes in it.

“Well, listen,” my captor from the city said, “I have affairs to tend to. I apprehended the thief for you, and you are now obliged to serve out justice on him. May I take my leave, sir?”

I wasn't angry at the man for having caught me, but it amazed me that a city person would allow me to be beaten that badly. Did they do that to the boys in the city, too? Immediately I made a vow never to move to a city.

"Oh, of course!" the old man said.

My captor was soon gone and I was at the mercy of the old man. He dragged me, with the crowd following us, to the front of his produce kiosk. I saw the pile of tomatoes before me and just wanted to close my eyes and never wake up from the nightmare I was living.

"Two men to hold the boy," the old man requested. Soon, two men volunteered to hold me. One held each arm as the old man rolled up his sleeves.

"There are too many tomatoes in the pile!" a young lady screamed. "This is horrible!"

"Will some man shut up his wife?" the old man barked.

I could hear the woman being struck, it was that loud, and again I shuddered until I almost vomited. Someone whose voice I did not recognize defended me, whereas someone whose I did recall had asked for me to be sent to the mullah. It made me dizzy.

The man pulled a tomato from the pile and said, "One!" just before I felt the cane hit my back. It was the blow of an old man, but it still stung so deeply that I thought I would black out. I heard the crowd take a deep breath, or perhaps that was the sound of my own breath being knocked out of me, I wasn't sure. I lost count five tomatoes. One lash became another. He hit my back repeatedly, and I could not breathe. It was eventually over and the two men let go of me, letting me fall to the ground. I could feel the sharp broken stones of the street poking into my cheek and arm, but there was no pain, just pressure. Where I had been held by my arms throbbled almost as much as where the old man had beat me.

"Twenty-nine lashes for twenty-nine tomatoes," the old man said proudly.

I could barely move. I twisted my head to the man and whispered, "You forgot to count the one I stole. Thirty

tomatoes in the pile.” I didn’t know what made me say it, but I was angry at everyone in the crowd—angry at Rezai most of all—so it must have been anger that forced the words out of me.

He looked amazed that I could even speak, let alone ask for another lash.

“You’ve learned your lesson,” the old man returned.

I tried to spit at him, but couldn’t, but he could tell what I was trying to do. The final lash quickly followed. I could see that his face was red with exhaustion. By then, I didn’t even feel the blow, but I did hear the wind being knocked out of my chest once more.

“The rotten little thief! Can’t believe it!” someone in the crowd said before turning away. Again, it was a voice I recognized.

It took a long time for me to get to my feet. I stumbled in the direction I knew I would find my house, trying not to look at anyone. I couldn’t tell how much time had passed since I’d stolen the tomato, or how long it had taken to give me those thirty lashes. I did know that if my torturer had been any younger, he would have killed me after the first five blows. I was dizzy, but could not feel any pain.

“How many tomatoes were in that pile, boy?” someone asked. I saw that it was the city man who had caught me. I was not afraid of him.

“Thirty,” I answered as boldly as I could muster.

“You survived *thirty* lashes?”

“Every one of them!” I returned, thinking, *I am a khan, son of a khan, grandson of a khan!*

The city man searched through his pocket. “Here is one *tuman* for every lash,” he explained as he handed the money to me. “Go to *Peiman-e-Omar* and buy something to eat there. The oven should be hot, so you will warm up a bit.”

I took the money, since I felt it was my right, and entered the teahouse. When I sat down, I became very dizzy and fell unconscious to the floor.

Upon awakening I heard music, and thought for sure that I had died from my wounds and gone to Paradise to join my grandfather the Khan. I could smell *khoresh* and *saji* bread cooking. No—my back ached so badly that I knew I must be in Hell, not Paradise. When I finally opened my eyes I saw Mr. Omar Zamini, the owner of the teahouse, standing above me.

“I washed your wounds and dressed you in some fresh clothes,” he said. “The money you had with you when you came in is in your sash pouch.”

“The clothes?” I muttered.

“They belong to my helper. An extra set. He’s about your size and age,” he said. “Now, who beat you?”

I didn’t reply.

“I take it you don’t want to talk. You’re Shahpouri’s son, yes?” he asked, sitting down. “I’ve seen you about now and again.”

I noticed then that I was in what must have been the back room of the teahouse. I could hear Kurdish men on the other side of the wall talking about the cold weather.

“Oh, you’re too sore to speak,” he added before taking out some things to his customers. He was soon back in the room, sitting on a stool. “Too sore to eat, then?” he asked, pointing to a plate of rice and yogurt.

“I can pay for the clothes and food you’ve given me,” I said, forcing the words. “I’m not a beggar.”

“That I know, if you’re the son of Shahpouri,” he said.

“He’s an honest man. I heard your house was robbed last night. Let your mother and father know that your family’s credit is good with me, should you need food supplies for the next week or so. He can pay back over enough time that it won’t hurt him.”

“I am certain that he’ll accept your hospitality” I said. “I can give you thirty *tuman* now if—”

“You’ll be needing those *tuman*,” Mr. Zamini replied. “Your credit is good with me, as I’ve said. It is my duty as a Muslim to protect those in hard times and offer my help.”

I eagerly ate the food he gave me and tried to stand, but couldn't.

"Whoever beat you came awfully close to crippling you," Mr. Zamini explained. "Those blows came close to your spine. Maybe I should send for your mother and father, and they can send to Baneh for a doctor. I know a bit about these things, but I'm no doc—"

"No," I insisted. "I've shamed them."

"Shamed them?" he asked, standing to again tend to his customers. "How?"

"I stole a tomato today," I said. "That's why I was beaten."

"All that for a tomato?" he asked. "I figured at least that you'd stolen the money you had on you to get a lashing like *that*, the way those two old men in the other are on about it."

"No," I said. "Someone gave me the money, honest. The lashes were for stealing a tomato."

"Well, *ensh-Allah*, it's over now. I'm sure you'll be a welcome sight at home, tomato or no tomato, lashes or no lashes. Your family is probably worried about you. It's almost noon now. Where do they think you are?"

I languished on my side to lessen the pain. "I'll try to go home after noon prayer call. I don't think I can make it before then," I said.

"After prayer call it is, then," Mr. Zamini said, leaving the room.

I closed my eyes and fell into a deep slumber. Just before sleep overcame me, I reached into my pocket and grasped tightly to the *tuman*. I was in too much pain to dream at all.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

“How much is this tomato worth to you?” he asked in reply, not wanting to have the exchange between them go on longer than was absolutely necessary. Should he appear too easy on a thief, he would stand out too boldly.

“If every dirty little boy with a bit of hunger in him were to steal just one of my tomatoes,” the old man returned, “I would not eat myself, and the good people here would have nowhere else to get their own. Were it my choice, I’d lash him once for every tomato in the pile he stole it from. This is war time, a time when people go hungry for lack of food.”

The boy was visibly horrified when he heard this decree, but the old man’s grasp was too firm for escape. All around the commotion the morning shoppers who had paid attention were either nodding or making comments to their neighbors about the punishment the boy had been threatened with.

“Why not send him up to Mullah Aziz and have him decide?” someone asked, shaking a closed fist.

The old man’s face went white at this pronouncement. “Listen, I want to punish the boy, not have him scarred for life. God Himself is merciful—just one lash for every tomato in the pile will be enough.”

“Well, listen,” he said, “I have affairs to tend to. I apprehended the thief for you, and you are now obliged to serve out justice on him. May I take my leave, sir?”

“Oh, of course!” the old man replied.

He wondered if the old man would carry out his threat. He was an aging thing, full of the pride of years, but he didn’t know if the pride would be enough to keep a man as old as that angry by the time it came time to actually hit the boy.

“the pathos-monger”

o maiden of lifes caravansera
i think of you from morn til end of day
youre like the karoun flowing wide and deep
i swim from shore to shore of you and play

you dont know that i love you when i lie down to sleep
tonight beside my wife you with your youthful dreams and
virgin aspirations will not think of me from your own bed i
am an old man with one child of my own who is older than
you

when i wake up in the morning and make my way
through the cold streets of our town past your stone
dwelling with hopes of seeing you even if you are veiled up
and locked behind custom out of my sight you will
probably be thinking of fond things not timeworn things

when you come to me to trade cuts of lamb for potatoes
eggplant and tomatoes you will be thinking about the stew
theyll all be going into that night and not of me for i am the
wrinkled old food monger

you wont be daydreaming about last weeks dinner at my
home with all the family you wont think it significant that
an aging *bazaari* was only acting drunken to cover over the
fact that the blood that rushed to his face rushed there at the
sight of your unveiled tresses and your glittering blue eyes

it wont matter to you at all that he made love to his wife
as passionately as a youngster that night only because with
the lanterns out he could imagine you in her place he could
feel your slender waist and round hips under him instead of
her sagging old faithful bags and it is nothing to you that
he went to sleep that night and dreamed he was fresh again
with you at his side high in the hills where the snow lasts
all year playing a reed flute like a sufi for you at his feet

i am quite certain that none of this will be reckoned at all when you wash with your sisters splashing water from the hills over your smooth unblemished body and when you laugh with your sisters about the small packet of sweets from esfahan you found at your doorstep youll be imagining some young man for what reason i cannot know since all the fine young men youll be imagining have long since been killed or relocated or have left iran altogether you certainly wont be thinking of me the food monger instead it will be someone long since buried in another province off kurdish soil who will have your soul

and when you awaken in the morning and stand up naked beside your bed youll be thinking about keeping your mother and father happy by going out to the market for the days things rather than about me that i will be thinking about the pleasures of that naked body of yours weighs nothing on the scale at all

oh perhaps you *will* think about me for a moment then but only in so far as one leg of your fathers lamb yields you three or four good sized eggplants half a dozen tomatoes and a few cucumbers if its a good cut thats what it will mean to you and why i will have the fortune to pass through your thoughts

when i say how are you doing today youll most likely reply that those last cucumbers made an excellent salad or something like that because thats all ill mean to you cucumbers and an excellent salad

when i used to sit you on my knee and tell you stories about the many brave things your kurdish forefathers did and of wolves in the hills and all the other things an old man tells a little girl well then you were just a little girl and your innocence was returned by mine im a decent man true to the mores of the prophet

my heart was pure then

but soon you were too old for my stories songs and tales so your father stopped sending you over to hear the fables and i would only see you when your family came over for dinner or we visited your house the less you sat on my

knee the more you grew and the fonder my heart became
towards you

i cannot give you anything perhaps you would be more
comfortable living with a food monger for a husband than
with a shepherd for a father but thats where your comforts
would end i cough terribly from the cold these days and
couldnt get very far without my cane so im sure it would
horrify you to bed with me

something happened today that reminded me of the
strength i could have given you had we met years ago had
you been born in my time for my time for me it makes me
think of the days when the hills meant nothing to my legs
when the cold meant nothing to my chest and when the
wind meant nothing to my ears now these things seem to
be my biggest enemy after time itself

a little rascal one who might even grow up to look like
one of the men you imagine left the sweets at your door
stole one of my tomatoes a good tomato it was too youd
probably think that one as old as myself would let it go not
out of lack of respect for justice but out of pure inability to
pursue the young scoundrel thats where youre wrong

i got up like a real fighter and chased the boy as i might
have chased a sheep on the run had i been a young
shepherd he was quick with my tomato in his hand my
heart nearly burst but i kept at him and finally he was in the
hands of one of the men on the street

i gave him a good scare waving my cane about up until
then it would have been enough just to have the boy caught
and shamed before his father that would have been enough
to put me straight at his age after all its not as if i myself
didnt come to odds with the odd fruit and vegetable monger
in my days as a child my father boxed me good for it
though and that was enough and whats more were *kurds*
with a reputation for bold brigandage to maintain i was
saddened then when no one stood out and grabbed him by
the ear and pulled him home by the lobe

but as i say nobody wanted him it became a matter of honor to give the boy his due and i was more than ready to do my bit in that regard

and when i had him in my grip i didnt let him go either i promised him a good whipping and gave him one didnt tire me out at all

most of all when he was gone i felt young this boy couldnt have been very old remember and id shown him not to play games with this old man you would have been amazed to see the stamina i still have in me but i dont recall seeing you anywhere in the crowd so i am almost certain you missed your chance to see what a champion i can still be when called upon

and of course you couldnt have seen when i hunted down the car of the man whod nabbed the little thief for me and i put the tomato on the seat of his car as a reward for his good deed except for the extra tomato or two i usually give you for your cuts im not one to give away produce for nothing i felt so young again that rewarding the good man was the least i could do

i regret having lashed the boy as much as i did but i dont regret the chance i got to be young again even if just for a moment

i think i am going to open the old chest in the back of my lodging the one with all the clothes in it that shah and his band of marauders forbade us kurds to wear i will pull out my tasseled turban of blue silk the vest embroidered by my mothers hand my baggy gray pants of homespun wool and my huge crimson sash into my sash i will put my pipe my pouch of tobacco and my fathers long curved dagger indeed when i was as young as all that i would walk the hills dressed like the loudest of dandies the last time i wore these clothes was after the allied invasion when everyone could come out of the hiding reza shah had forced upon us

ah yes tonight ill be going to the teahouse dressed like a peacock to listen to a few of the good tale-tellers you wont be there of course among the men but it would be nice if you could be because ill be standing up tonight myself i

should think even if just to tell one of the fables i used to tell you when you sat on my knee they dont really care there just so long as its long and its interesting one night someone stood up and made a good song up on the spot out of what amounted to little more than a grocery list his wife had told him to remember before trekking off to baneh if a grocery list is good enough for them coming from a poorly dressed shepherd how much better a tall tale coming from a well-dressed merchant ought to be

you wont be there to hear me but i tell you that the blood will be flowing through my veins and i wont need the flames of the fire in mr mehrdadis hearth to keep me warm ill be thinking about you captivating you in my mind with one of the longest tales i can remember

there will be shepherds and hills and hunters and treachery in the tale and perhaps an old hag living in a cave i shall sing parts of it loudly weep at times and have the whole teahouse crowd pounding their feet by the time i am finished i havent decided which one im going to tell yet since it has been a long time since ive had a flame in my heart bright enough to light the pages of my memory of such things

but you wont know that im telling it all for you youll be sitting with your sisters knitting shawls thinking about how many eggplants youll be needing tomorrow and about the mysterious young man who knows of your fondness for sweets at least ill be there somewhere the eggplant monger it is good that you must eat so that i may be there frequently for whatever reason

now i squat here at my stand behind piles of vegetables rubbing my sore hand waiting for the muezzin to call us to prayer the people pass by me as if they were floating on the creek

i remember the rivers and creeks i used to go swimming in up in the hills when i was a young man an old faithful friend and i hes long since dead now would go up there in the mornings the walks were long and arduous but we were young and caneless ready for anything and besides

our lungs were strong and we would sing as we went to pass the time indeed we thundered so that i am sure our cries must have been heard from here to saqqez wed jump into any freezing body of water then crazy and stupid youth that we were how i wish now it had been you with me had it been you we would have made love in the grass at the side of the creek under the summer sun dressed only in the warm breeze nobody would have found us up there so far away and into the hills

nowadays the only ones who find themselves up there in those hills are rebels that is where some of abadouns men have gone you know theyre not *all* dead or exiled to far off lands the ones you probably dream about taking you away in their arms every night the ones for whom you are saving your maidenhood are living up in the hills in little tents practicing the art of killing with pointed sticks smoking only the tobacco they grow themselves and saving their bullets for the first unwary caravan they choose to loot for supplies

if i were younger who knows i might very well be up in those hills myself ready to put out the flame of the oppressors you know when mullah mostafa barzani came to iran from iraq i almost went up to mahabad by foot and joined his group i was such a fiery idealist then had i done so i would have a long pointed stick in my hand instead of a cane and then maybe youd be thinking of me when the candy ends up mysteriously at your door and when the rumors tell of another group of brigands attacking a snowbound army truck in the pass

oh listen to me an old man dreaming of being up in the hills with the best of them ready to jump out in front of moving caravans with explosives strapped to my body i catch one little boy and bring him to justice and already i am some kind of war hero you dont know that you do this to me do you

i dream like this for you

sure all you see of me is an old tomato seller a wrinkled old man who sometimes smells terribly of rotten cucumbers

and potato dust you dont see the fire in my heart or the
light in my eyes you dont hear the poetry i write for you as
i count my dates

i do that you know but you dont know it how could you
have even guessed i place down a date and a verse comes
to me another date another verse then another and again a
stitch finally another date

just like a *rubaai*

hakim khayyam has written nothing compared to the
many verses i have written for you just this week as i sort
my fruit well i am an illiterate man and must go to the dry
goods seller mr mehrdadi to read my mail and compose any
letters for me but i am not referring to written words

i could have been a literate man i suppose and that
might have impressed you then maybe you would come to
me not only for fruits and vegetables but also for letter
writing you wouldnt just think of me when you were
hungry then would you you might think of me also when
you wanted some anonymous lovers poetry read to you

perhaps it is better that i am not a literate man then since
as one of the few left in this town id probably end up being
the translator for you and some young man trying to woo
you with poetry that was written down with pen and ink not
just piles of dates of course hed come to me to write down
what he was saying which hed then give to you and then
youd come to me to read it out for you

some laugh that would be

i see now that it is better that i ignored shahs teachers on
their donkeys with their little blackboards and pamphlets
altogether they had nothing to tell me about kurdish
anyway what with their always barking in farsi youd be
expecting a kurdish transcriber and translator i am an old
man and couldnt keep up with all that go ask mehrdadi

oh what a story i will tell at the teahouse tonight my
love my mind wanders too much but you probably think
that it doesnt stray too far from my little stand at the bazaar
perhaps it is better that way since i can at least this way

PASSING THROUGH — COHEN BENJAMIN

swim from shore to you and play and imagine you and me
up in the hills of our beloved kurdistan

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

He quickly left the center of the commotion and made every effort to be as far from the noise about the stolen tomato as he could. After negotiating a few quick turns around the spectators, he was soon at the door of *Peiman-e-Omar*, a small teahouse.

Once inside, he squatted with his knees up to his chest in the traditional rural manner and lit a cigarette. The place was hollow and empty except for the proprietor and his servant boy.

The proprietor saw him and quickly had his boy run over with tea and sugar cubes. He put the cube between his tongue and palette and sipped the steaming hot tea, letting it wash down the smoke as it went. It was sweet and made his mind numb to his dilemma for a moment, but soon his mouth was sour again.

“Go chop some wood for the ovens, boy!” the proprietor, a man in his mid-fifties, cried out. The boy soon left and the proprietor went to the front door and locked it.

“*Salam*, Omar,” he greeted the proprietor.

“*Salam*,” Omar replied. He sat across from him so that the pot of tea was between them on the worn red and black carpet.

“What can I see today if I look into your cup?” he asked, taking another sip to warm his ticklish throat. He glanced over his shoulder at the antique wine cup that had been hanging on the wall at that spot for as long as he had been passing through Abadoun.

“Omar’s Cup”

Jamshid into his Cup would often gaze,
And if we with his bowl could know our days,
We’d quickly run to quaff that other wine
Rather than know what price Tomorrow pays.

High on the wall it hangs at *Peiman-e-Omar*, overlooking the main room of the small teahouse. It is cracked at places along its lip. Deep at its glazed bottom hunts a forgotten nobleman, spear held high, ready to deliver the *coup de grâce* to the wounded boar, but never releasing to claim the kill. The voices that fill the room echo clearly through it—it hears everything.

As has always been so at daybreak, it hears the bolt of the back door being thrown vigorously open by Omar, owner of the teahouse. Minutes pass before he comes out of the back room and into sight of the bowl. It sees him readying the place for customers. He then disappears again for a while and the boy comes out. This is all as it always has been.

The boy passes in front of it and looks closely at the hunter, holding up his broom in imitation of the hunter.

“Playing again?” comes Omar’s voice from the shadows. “Get to work, boy!”

The boy glances quickly at the bowl again before resuming his usual chores of sweeping the small carpets that are scattered all about the rectangular room. The first customer of the day enters, sits at his usual spot far across from the bowl, and begins to flip cards out on the floor before him.

“Reza-jaan,” Omar yells out a greeting as he approaches the man.

The bowl hears the cards being shuffled and manipulated in the man's hands. It sees the tea being poured into another cup as wine was once poured into it.

"What news?" the man says, still throwing his cards in front of himself.

"It's going to be a cold winter," Omar replies, sitting across from him.

"Your father burnt! I can feel the cold well enough. I mean what have you heard about my shipment of things from Baneh? You motherless pauper." The echoes in the bowl ring of camaraderie.

"Your things have not arrived from Esfahan, I'm afraid," Omar consoles his friend. "It isn't easy these days, with the war. What do you want when we can hardly get rice in?"

"Penniless dog! Oh, well, *ensh-Allah*." He tips his head back and finishes his tea.

"Go like a lion, come like a lion, *Reza-jaan*" Omar says as he closes the door behind the parting man.

"He didn't pay!" the boy's voice echoes loudly through the bowl.

"He pays when his supplies come, mullah," Omar returns with his own echo. "I add it into the figures." He then stands and again goes into the back room, out of sight of it.

Not much time passes before another man enters the teahouse. Omar comes out to see who it is, and then says to the boy, "Give him tea and sugar cubes. He has no cubes!"

The boy runs across the room with supplies on a tarnished silver serving platter not unlike the platters that had once been used to place the bowl before noblemen at great festivals. The man puts a cube in his mouth and drinks his tea.

"Go chop some wood for the ovens, boy!" Omar hollers. The boy soon runs into the back room and the proprietor walks to the front door and locks it.

"*Salam*, Omar," the man's heavy greeting echoes.

"*Salam*."

“What can I see today if I look into your cup?” he says, peering over at it on the wall.

“German marks,” Omar says. Their voices have become almost as silence, but it can hear and see everything in its domain. “This one is special.”

“Otherwise they wouldn’t have called for me while I was resting from the last ‘special’ one.” He taps his chest.

The bowl has seen and heard this one before. He comes infrequently but consistently, always talking of mysterious things, always almost silent with his words.

“They didn’t see you at least. Or so I have heard said during my weekly trip to Baneh for supplies,” Omar says. “No, this one is *special* special. The last one was rich, and we needed his patronage. This one is more than rich. We need him for other reasons.”

“Political?”

Omar nods his head just enough to be seen from across the room.

“Do I know him?”

“The Bolbol,” Omar replies. He makes a gesture with his hand. It has heard this name before, used by another man it has sometimes seen Omar speaking with.

“I’m sure he’s not in good physical shape.”

“Prison informants say he’s as healthy as you or me,” Omar replies.

For a while there is only silence not unlike the silence that comes to the teahouse only for brief periods every night, or the silence that follows an important part of a storyteller’s tale in front of the hearth. “It’s not as if I have a real choice, Omar-*jaan*, is it? How ready will he be?”

“The right guards have been oiled.” Omar is making another gesture with his hand, but it cannot see, for it cannot move to get a better view. “It shouldn’t squeak too loudly if you follow instructions you will be given by our eye in Baneh. I only know as much as I’ve told you, of course. What news have you for me from Baghdad?”

“I... Nothing of interest.” Again, all is as silent as the heartbeat of the hunter painted under the glaze, until the

echoes begin again with, “Say, Omar, I’ve got a question for you.”

“A question? It has been a long time since you’ve come to me with one of those. Well, you know, there are the usual ones. Is this one of them?”

He looks at the hunter on the wall again and then at the empty space on the other side of him and finally says, “Not the usual business-related questions, no.”

“Oh, good. You know, just because we’re brothers of the order doesn’t mean it always has to be business, now, does it?” Omar pours some tea into his glass and sips the steaming golden fluid.

“Right. You understand what I mean. Anyway, the question,” the other’s voice echoes past the hunter.

“Ask me, and I’ll do my best to answer.”

“When do real people get factored into our equations, *dadash*?”

Omar is rubbing his hands on his own cup, saying, “Do you want a politically motivated answer, my friend, or the answer from my heart? I am a dissident, you know, and have a natural bias that is influenced by our mutual agenda.”

“Whatever.”

No echoes, until, “I wonder the same thing, when I dream, when I sleep, when I’m not keeping guard on my heart. Remember the Revolution? Those were insane days, when we had so many hopes, you know. No one wanted to believe that any free empire, any democracy, would do their worst to us dissidents. But, as the saying goes, a slap in the face is better than empty promises of *halvah*.” He slaps his own face. “We take what blessings we can get.”

“I just want to know, Omar, what makes so few more important than so many? What gives us the right to put the scales out on the table and the weigh souls?”

Smiling, pouring more tea, he resonates, “Are you having an ideological battle so close to your retirement?”

“I know I am close to my reward. I’ll be processed, officially erased, put through some painfully slow

relocation process and sent to Sweden to live out my twilight years as a cook, I'm sure." He slowly pulls his right forefinger across his neck and makes as dealing the prey the final blow. "But what is more important?" he continues to resound. "The needs of the many or the needs of the few?"

Omar leans back a bit and strokes his chin, making noises that carry out into the whole room from deep within his throat. "You know your oaths to *Azadi*, yes?"

"Indeed." He sits straight backed. "My integrity to those oaths has never been in question."

"Why do you run bodies from Teheran to Ankara?"

Omar gestures toward the man with one hand on his chin, the other with an open palm toward the roof, and a strong shrug. "Why do I keep the supplies flowing from Baneh to the border? We both know that the money is poor. *Azadi* payroll is sweat and bullets, *baba-jaan*." He sweeps both of his hands, pointing to everything in the room. "Our Swiss accounts aren't lofty by any estimation. When was your last bit of rest? Had it not been for your wound, you wouldn't have had one for five years, right? I can't remember that I've ever had rest myself."

"Yes, to all of this." Still, he is rocking back and forth, sometimes looking at the bowl, sometimes looking at Omar, sometimes looking down at the carpet they are squatting on.

"Then, I take it you are an agent solely for some personal ideological reason, my friend, as I am? You have given your one life for the good of the many, right? You were recruited by *Azadi* when they saw that special quality in you, right?"

He nods in reply to Omar.

"The only answer I can give you, you have already given yourself years ago by joining us and putting your one life on the line for the tenets."

"I suppose so, Omar-*jaan*." He is no longer moving at all. "I will think about it and try to pry the wisdom from the

pile of stones you have presented me with.” Reaching across, he grabs Omar’s hand and slaps it heartily.

“Is there something bothering you from Baghdad that you haven’t told me?”

“Omar-*jaan*, I—” His hand is over his mouth and the sound in the room and the echoes in the bowl cease.

After some time, Omar gets up, unlocks the front door, and wanders to sit in another corner of the room. The boy returns with some wood. The man finishes his pot of tea, places some coins on the floor, and quickly leaves the teahouse.

“At least he pays!” the boy hollers.

“Let me worry about my own purse,” Omar says. “You should brood less about the affairs of others, boy, and more about your own. Always worried about money. Why, I bet you don’t even give alms.”

“But, I have to get my pay every—”

“That wasn’t the point. I give you something for your help around here whether they pay me or not, don’t I, boy? What about giving alms? You have to keep your account with God and the Prophet balanced whether the customers here are louts or princes, you know.” Omar waves his hand at the boy as if throwing a spear made of air.

“I—”

“You don’t give alms, do you? You worry and fret about other people’s money, but you just horde your own, boy. Just like Mullah’s friend, Mr. Rezai. Charity, you little cur, befits anyone, young and old alike. You ought to—”

The door swings open, letting in a gust of air that shakes the bowl on its hinge. Another boy enters. Blood like that forever pouring from the wounded boar has stained his shirt bright red. The boy sits at a stool and falls over onto the floor, out of its sight behind a barrel.

“Good God!” Omar’s oath echoes throughout the room and into the bowl so loudly that it shakes again, ringing a bit against the hard wood behind it. He quickly runs over to the barrel and slides it far enough for it to see the boy again. “He has been beaten, Ali! Water, bring me water!”

The boy disappears for a moment and then returns with a clay jug of water. Omar splashes some of the water on the boy's face, but the boy remains motionless.

"Help me carry him to the cot in the back," he says.

Soon, the room is again empty and motionless. Again with a gust of wind from outside, the door swings open and two men enter. They walk over to the carpet that sits directly under the hanging bowl. This is their place, and the bowl has seen them many times. Their conversation rarely differs.

"Our carpet is vacant for us," it always begins, from one or the other, sometimes from both at once.

"Damned war," the fat one always says.

"War," the other always returns. "What do you want from it?"

"Gets to me. Makes my heart beat sour. Chills my bones deeper than the wind from the hills."

"We're Kurds," is always the reply. "Built for this kind of beating."

"Used to be such a big village. So big. So many of us. Young ones tending the flocks."

"Thousands. Oh, the festivals."

"It's going to be a bitter winter. The sheep are all going to die; they're already half dead from cold and lack of proper care."

"Thousands. How many you figure? Just count up all the empty shacks and—"

"Where's the boy? Boy! Our tea!"

This is where the conversation varies from every other day the bowl has heard it. Usually, the boy has already served their tea and they begin to talk about how the heat of the tea takes away the bitterness of the winter air. The boy has not come yet and they are at a loss for words for a while.

"That cup up there isn't Kurdish," the fat one says, pointing at the hunter. "I'd be able to tell if it was. I have an eye for these things, I do."

"What you think it is, then?"

The fat one stands to look closely at the boar and the nobleman, so close that the bowl can smell the fresh air that hangs around his body. He has never examined the bowl before. He sits down again and pounds on the floor with the palm of his hand.

“Boy, our tea!” he hollers so loudly that the cup shakes on the nail holding it up. “Can’t tell you,” he then says to his companion. “Could be from Eastern Azerbaijan, but I don’t know. We’ll ask Omar. If he’s even here. Boy!”

The boy comes out with tea. “I’m sorry,” he says, “but a boy just came in, all beaten up, and we—”

“Oh, that thief boy,” one says. “Hope you’re not giving him *too* much attention—the boy is a scoundrel, he is. He stole something at the bazaar and got a beating for it. Watch your silver back there, if you know what’s good for you.”

“From Shiraz,” the thin one says.

“What?” their server asks nervously. “He is *Shirazi*?”

“No! Not the little tramp thief. The bowl. From Shiraz. The *bowl*.” He points at the bowl with a thin, spear-like finger.

“No. The boar hunting. I’d say Azari. Maybe Tabriz,” the fat one argues. “I told you; I know these things.”

“Shiraz.”

“We’ll ask Omar. Boy, get your master out here.”

The boy quickly leaves the room, and Omar comes in his place.

“I’m sorry for being—”

“We heard. Watch that thief you are harboring back there. Lashed for stealing.”

“Shiraz?” the thin one says, pointing at the bowl.

“Pardon?”

“Made in Shiraz?” the fat one explained, he too pointing. “He thinks it’s *Shirazi*, I say Tabriz.”

“My father got it from his father, and it was as old as the mountains then. No one knows,” Omar replies. “It’s a treasure, really. Maybe it’s from Persepolis. A few of my friends in Baneh think that it’s a *Sassani* relic. Maybe it’s

even Jamshid's Bowl, I don't know. I wanted to draw the picture on a piece of paper and send it to a friend in Yazd to have it identified, but who has the time these days to draw up the bottom of bowls?"

The fat one chokes on his tea.

"Jamshid's Bowl, then, huh? Well, maybe," the thin one says.

"No one really knows about the bowl, as of yet, since, as I say, it hasn't been appraised or anything—got it from my father. I've never filled it with wine and looked into it like King Jam. I don't want to know where I'm headed with my future," Omar says before leaving the two to resume their normal conversation.

"The tea really takes the bite out of the cold," the fat one says. "I need my tea in the morning. Gets me through my *namaz*."

"I go and hide in my house for prayer," the thin one says.

"Out on the street, in the cold, in the rain, I say," the fat one returns. "We need it if we're going to beat back those bastard Iraqis. Pray to God that these Iraqi bastards all choke on our sweet Iranian air."

"Say," the thin one changes the pattern of what is always said, "if that really was Jam's Bowl, you think he'd have it just hanging up there on the wall like that? Not very proper, for an old trinket like that. A war raging on right now, you know...."

"Oh, come on, now, we know better than that. He probably just bought it in Baneh at the bazaar from a huckster, and chipped it like that for—what's the word I want—"

"Effect?"

"Yes, that. Made it look old. Omar's a real anything monger himself, always buying and selling old junk here and there for everyone and anyone. Could sell a wagon load of sheep shit to a shepherd, if you know what I mean. Full of stories. What you want from a teahouse keeper?"

“Well, I’d be a bit spooked if it were Jamshid’s Cup, you know. The way things have been for us up here in the hills these days, I’d rather not know of the days ahead.”

The fat one takes a sip of tea and then reaches out to touch it. It has not been touched since it was first placed there by Omar many years before. While feeling its lip the fat one nicks his finger on the chipped surface and starts to bleed.

“Damnation! I cut myself on it.”

“The spear?”

The fat one reaches across as if ready to hit his friend on the side of the head. “On the bowl, you fatherless dog. The bowl. It cut me.”

The thin one looks first at the fat man’s finger and then at the bowl. “Not that bad of a cut. Not too much blood. There, there. Now, how many you figure there are left in this town, anyway?”

“Starving sheep, starving cats, or starving people? Damned war,” the fat one always says.

“So, you say about two hundred of us left?”

“More than that. A good deal more than that. I’d say more around another hundred.”

“He can’t kill us all, can he?”

“Hussein. Damned Hussein.”

“We’re Kurds—*built* for it, though,” the thin one always echoes. “God put white fire in our hearts and tempered iron in our bones.”

Another enters the teahouse, and soon afterward, another. Soon there are so many in the place that one conversation is hard to discern from every other, but all talk of war and of loss, and of bitter winter cold.

The fat man stands to leave, and as he stands, the sounds of his old bones cracking fill the bowl. “Almost noon. Time to wash up for prayer, old man. Put in a word for my boys, will you? A little extra begging wouldn’t hurt none.”

“Old bugger yourself. Sure. The boys. Tomorrow, then?” the thin one always replies.

“Tomorrow, then,” the bowl hanging on the wall of teahouse had always heard.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

“German marks,” Omar said simply as he sat down to join him. “This one is special.”

“Otherwise they wouldn’t have called for me while I was resting from the last ‘special’ one,” he remarked. He tapped his chest where he had taken the bullet during the flight and made a facsimile of a pistol with his thumb and forefinger.

Omar’s eyes screwed up at this. “They didn’t see you at least,” he said. “Or so I have heard said during my weekly trip to Baneh for supplies. No, this one is *special* special. The last one was rich, and we needed his patronage. This one is more than rich. We need him for other reasons.”

“Political?” he said, wondering how many more bullets his chest would sustain before he met his maker. Maybe if he died relocating a political, he thought, God would find a special place for him in Paradise.

Omar’s nod was enough reply.

“Do I know him?”

“The Bolbol,” Omar replied. He made wings with his hands and fluttered about.

He knew the name—*The Nightingale*—but then again, everyone in Iran with any political consciousness at all knew of Babak Bakhteyari—“Bolbol” for the double *beh* of his name—the Nightingale. Some believed this man was destined to lead the counterrevolution, if one ever came, while others attached themselves to him with hopes of overthrowing him in turn and eventually having their own way with Iran, according to their own agenda. More than a few, if given the chance, would elect this man as the President of a Democratic Republic of Iran, since he was considered by most to be the ideological successor to Mohammed Mosaddeq. To free the Nightingale from his

cage was the dream of every freedom fighter he'd ever overheard. Since Bakhteyari was an underground radio celebrity, and not a poster icon, very few could recognize him on sight, but there was a problem that he felt could not be overlooked.

"I'm sure he's not in good physical shape. I'm in no shape myself after that bullet to be pulling a tortured, battered prisoner over any walls by the belt."

"Prison informants say he's as healthy as you or me," Omar tried to calm him.

He thought about it for a while. The thought of having as big a political as the Bolbol on his record with *Azadi* pleased him enough to smile at Omar. "It's not as if I have a real choice, Omar-*jaan*, is it? How ready will he be?"

"The right guards have been oiled," he replied, rubbing his thumb and forefinger together. The mountain air had long since dried his fingers so that they sounded like sandpaper rubbing against soapstone. "It should not squeak too loudly if you follow instructions you will be given by our eye in Saqqez. I only know as much as I've told you, of course. What news have you for me from Baghdad?"

"I—" he began. Should he tell Omar about the gas? Would Omar be in the cellar of the teahouse putting away supplies or picking out a wine to go with his watery lamb soup?

"Nothing of interest," he then continued.

For a time they talked of personal things. Some time into the conversation, Omar asked a trying question.

"Is there something bothering you from Baghdad that you haven't told me?" Omar pried, looking intently at his face as if to gauge his total response rather than just the sound of his words.

"Omar-*jaan*, I—" He stopped himself again. He knew that Omar could tell there was something on his mind, but he relied on the fact that the Eyes of Freedom never questioned their brothers when they started but did not finish a thought. Omar stood and unlocked the front door. The boy soon returned with some wood for the oven.

He finished what remained in his small pot of tea. When the heat of the tea had entered into every part of his body, he left a few *rial* more than he should have and then parted with all haste. As he quit the teahouse, he spotted the young boy from the marketplace. The boy could hardly walk, let alone flee, and he was soon up beside him. He was obviously too sore from the thrashing he'd received for stealing the tomato to care about his captor's approaching him.

"How many tomatoes were in that pile, boy?" he asked.

"Thirty," the boy replied.

"You survived *thirty* lashes? Good God!"

"Every one of them!" the boy returned as proudly as he could bleat from his now dry lips.

He searched his pocket to find some money. "Here is one *tuman* for every lash," he explained as he handed the money to the boy. "Go to *Peiman-e-Omar* and get something to eat there. The oven will be hot soon, so you will warm up a bit."

The boy took the money and did as he was told. He wondered how long his compensatory deed would matter. Three hundred *rial*. One rial for every citizen of Abadoun. One tomato. *Is one tomato worth thirty lashes, or even thirty tuman?* he began to wonder. *Then again, just how much is one tomato worth?*

Since it was not the way of *Cheshman* to reveal these matters before absolutely necessary, he hadn't known before the visit with Omar who he would be smuggling out of Teheran on this run. The Bolbol was a big prize, bigger than any other he had ever had the opportunity to help escape captivity. Indeed, unlike so many others he had smuggled out of Iran, the Bolbol was in his mind a worthy endeavor. Perhaps.

That is to say, the rescue of the Bolbol that existed in the popular conscience of Iran was a worthy venture. If he rescued anything less than *that* Nightingale, the Babak Bakhteyari he was familiar with from the optimistic political buzzing.... It made him think of the admonishment

he had once received from his father for buying a trinket from a *bazaari* in Tabriz: “They paint their sparrows to look like nightingales.” Had the people, in need of a nightingale of peace, painted the colors of a nightingale on the drab feathers of a sparrow?

One nightingale (or sparrow?) for three hundred peasants. One tomato for thirty lashes, ten *rial* for every lash. It made his head spin.

How long would it take a group of old, invalid, and suckling fear-crazed Kurds to escape their village? Two hours? They’d be out well before the noon muezzin was scheduled to cry. The gas wouldn’t reach them in the hills. There was a still chance they could be warned and would survive the gas. They would come back to poisoned water flowing in a tainted creek, but they were tenacious and would live nonetheless. Other Kurds had managed to survive the poisoned water—direct gas on the skin and into the lungs was another thing.

He knew there were only two *Azadi* in the whole village on any regular basis. Omar and her. She comforted, he informed over tea. Every eye had a function. Two eyes to a village, or at least those important villages that happened to be on the treacherous road to Saqqez. Nothing in the tenets of *Azadi* obligated him to warn them—theirs was an order of secrecy more than loyalty. Indeed, the rules forbade him from speaking with them more than once in a given pass through. He had already let his chance to speak with those two about it pass.

One tomato. Thirty lashes. Three hundred *rial*, one for every.... He held his head in his hands to stop from spinning and falling down. Two hands, one on either side of his aching head, holding him steady—not an unusual sight, given the chill in the air and the bite his ears were taking.

And there was the one town mullah. Would the mullah listen to his story? Would the mullah order the town evacuated? What would it take to convince Mullah Aziz that his story about gas had a basis in some reality? After

all, the whole idea sounded insane and very few would believe that some stranger passing through on his way to Saqqez would know so much about the Iraqis' battle plans—without something to support the claim. Why should a stranger with wild tales of impending gas attacks from Iraq be believed by the pragmatic, decree obeying mullah from Khozestan Province?

“A Letter Home”

This morn I heard the call to do *namaz*,
It rang in Teheran, Esfahan, Shiraz,
But even louder than the muezzin
Was the cry of a much greater cause.

Karim-jaan, Salam:

Since my last letter to you I have received three from you, and I hope it is enough to say that I’m embarrassed.

If this admission will not give you any comfort, remember that my arthritis has been terrible during these colder months, and for some time I have only with pain taken pen to paper. Given that hardly anyone hereabouts can read even a scribble, I’ve had very little need to hurt my hands by writing anything longer than my signature in my usual official religious and civic capacities as mullah of Abadoun. The most recent paper that I’ve put my signature to since last writing you was a wedding certificate for a young woman and a veteran from Shiraz, and given that the woman is now well enough along with child, I calculate that her pregnancy has shown me to be a procrastinator.

Karim, believe me when I say it’s not as if I haven’t had many things to discuss. You know from my last letter that my responsibilities have taken their toll upon my health so that most of my lighter, less onerous duties—and even some of the more ponderous ones—have been delegated to my assistant, Mr. Rezai. He handles his duties well enough, although I have heard on more than one occasion from citizens that he is too likely to turn a blind eye on the poor than the Prophet would demand of a good Muslim, and it bothers me that he would ignore the alms. That aside, though, he has certainly lightened my load so that I may

occupy myself more with spiritual matters than worldly ones, which has given me more time to pray for our sister.

And how is Ayesha? Any news I have of her has come from the appropriate hospital staff in Teheran, rather than from someone with any vested interest in her emotional, physical, and spiritual welfare. You wrote that you have been visiting her once a week, so I assume you have a better idea of her condition than the doctors. Sometimes I feel that they must think I am an idiot for not seeing through their encouraging words—I am a public servant of many years of service myself and well know the honey with which they sweeten their diagnoses and useless observations and encouragement.

Next time you see her, please talk with her about the many days the three of us spent running about in the hills as children. Given her state, perhaps the best thing for her are those memories. I know that, as my hands grow pained and my knees less sure, nostalgia keeps me from sinking too far into despair, and it very well may keep her spirits high, too. If nothing else, perhaps you will get some benefit in remembering those days as you pull them up from your own childhood to tell her.

There, I'm back from my tea and my fingers have taken a little relief from the brazier. If only you can keep Ayesha from slipping too deeply into her despair, Karim. Certainly I look forward to my reward as God will deal it to me, but as far as I am concerned, every day that we stand waiting for His hand to lift us up to His glorious side, we are obliged to paint our own heaven on the greasy glass of our spectacles, if you understand the point. Paradise awaits us, sure, but we ought to keep ourselves from despair's door as long as we have the mental faculties to do so. (Perhaps this is why I have taken solace far too often in wine and Hafez's verse of late. I am old now, and the spectacles are that much more greasy these days than they were when I was a little boy reciting Koran at that riverbank near Nanour.)

You know, Karim, that there has been a growing despair in Abadoun among those who remain here, since I have

talked about this with you on more than one occasion. There also seems to be a growing hostility among the parents of those young men whom I had the terrible and unwelcome responsibility of selecting for military duty. Not being a parent myself, and not having a compassionate and nurturing wife to nag at my side—to remind me of my own softer feelings on the matter—I have, in the past, distanced myself from this heavy burden by altogether ignoring the backside of the mule. I'm afraid that the product of my ignorance stinks so badly now that I can no longer ignore it. What's more, this fertilizer has yielded an awful crop.

Firstly, there are no young men left in Abadoun for me, as the responsible appointee, to send to war. I didn't empty the town of them all; some of took flight before my orders came from the appropriate committee. Still others fled into the wilderness during selection, ready to try their luck against the wild beasts and the elements rather than be sent off to fight the Iraqis.

Certainly, the anger of these young men's parents must well up inside them as they walk down the streets in the morning only to see old hags, buzzards (among whom I am numbered!), cripples, young children, and unwed, weeping maidens. Certainly, the old wives feel anger when they are forced to send their ripe old husbands out to shepherd the flocks. When they were having their ninth child, I told them not to worry, since, "God will fill their bellies and the earth will carry their weight." Now that I have sent those same sons to war, what can I tell them?

I've tried to give boisterous sermons on the value of the bravery of those who have died in *jihad* for the Imams, Karim, but you know as well as I do that sermons mean little when held up against the sorrow of their unwed daughters and the ancient, tradition-laden clan names that will never be carried on. These are *Kurds*!

I think a grave error was made in asking these Kurds to fight in this war. This whole thing is fought across an ill-conceived line on a map they probably wouldn't even

recognize if it were put in front of them in full color. Besides the evident problems of communication between Kurds and Persians, there are ideological and spiritual issues that demand compassion and understanding from Persian Muslims.

Kurds use their hearts and souls to write their ideology on, and you know how hard it can be to blot that kind of ink and write over it. I have seen too many angry mothers glaring at me in the streets of late to doubt my hypothesis in this regard—they want spiritual guidance, but they need their sons to till the soil, tend the flocks, and give them grandsons who will in turn praise God.

If I am to win the hearts and souls of men, I must treat them with the soft hands of a miracle worker, not the sharp sword of high-powered zeal. Even the Prophet understood the value of making concessions with “people of a book” when he gave Christians and Jews special consideration in the Law. We just must have the eyes to see that the Kurds’ book is written in struggle and pain, a language common to all men in these days of war, except those who have forgotten how to read it.

How can the various councils and committees understand what I, a lone representative of Islam in this barren, devastated frontier, must face? I am educated in Koran and Hadith and can quote with great accuracy the pedigree of almost any civic decision. Since you came with me to Mecca, you know the pilgrimage is many years behind me already and that my cup already rests full in Heaven, waiting. What this town needs is a young zealot with nothing behind him to lose and everything in front of him to gain by making enemies of these Kurds. You see from the length of the discussion that it is a matter I carry upon my soul with a groan and a gnashing of teeth.

I have distanced myself in other ways, Karim. How many times did you beg me to find a wife, to settle down, to have children? When I used to visit you in Teheran in the days before the war, you paraded prospects before me, ready to negotiate with their families, should I approve of

any. Now I am too old and so arthritic that I couldn't act as a man should with a wife in bed. Certainly my never having lived the life of a husband and father has influenced those around me and spread out into the town itself like a poison.

Perhaps I would have been better able to serve God had I married, Karim. I often weigh the balance and feel that married life would have tempered my steel and hardened my resolve with these Kurds. They all have many children themselves, just as you will find in any rural village in any province in Iran. When I officiate at a marriage (as I've said, it's been a while even for that), I feel emotion for the holy thing that has been sealed before the eyes of God, but I do not feel the fervor that a father would feel in seeing his own daughter given away in marriage to an honest shepherd. These people are a hardy lot, full of life, honest and callused by real toil, Karim, and you, as a father and husband yourself, probably understand them better than I do, even though you left Kurdistan for Teheran so many years ago now.

I want so much for these people to come out into the streets when Mr. Rezai calls for them. I want so much for them to love God with all their hearts, as I do. You, Karim, know how much I have given up so that I may be close to God and smiled upon by the Imams, don't you? You know how many times I said no to your pleas to get me out of the books and into the fields.

On a cold night, we can hear the Iraqi shells on towns not unlike our own. We all know of the sons who died while serving in sweet Khozestan Province. If Khoramshahr, hometown of our forefathers, could be flattened and erased from the map for the Imams and the Glory of God, my brother, then tiny Abadoun certainly could also, and God's angels wouldn't blink.

Karim, you see that I have many things facing me every day, and that my prayer mat has grown thin from the scraping of my knees and the pounding of my forehead. At least my arthritis hasn't kept me from praying as often as a good Muslim should. Please, remind Ayesha of the simple

days—if not for her only, then for me. She certainly knows nothing of my despair, since I am confident that you do not torment her with reports of my situation.

I will be sending this letter to you not by the usual, official channels, but by means of a close friend who owes me a favor of this magnitude. Prudence and frankness are often enemies. *Ensh-Allah*, it shall be delivered straight to your hand, unopened.

Take care of our sister and your own family and remember to Love God as I have always loved Him. Karim, believe me when I say that I am sorry for not having written sooner than this—I am your sacrifice, dear brother. I will write more often, I promise before God, if only so that I'll suffer but a little bit every time....

God Protect,

Mahmoud

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

There was the One Eye that could convince Mullah. He knew that. Everyone knew that. Show the One Eye. That is what it would take for a report of impending gas attack to be believed. Nobody knew where it was, this eye, but it would only take his showing the mullah the eye, and his story would be believed, since it was a part of the common political consciousness of this part of Iran that the Eyes of Freedom saw things. They knew things. An Eye would be believed.

Believed, and then shot. He would tell them what he knew, rescue the village, and then be shot as a traitorous agent. Shot for One Eye, just as the boy had been beaten senseless for that one tomato. It would not take more than one bullet this time, since it would be true to its target, unlike the one he'd taken in the chest while running away under cover of night.

Three young women were washing breakfast dishes in the muddy creek that ran along the main road along which the bazaar clung. He could tell enough, even with his limited knowledge of their dress customs, to know that they were unwed, just like his lover in the caravanserai.

He stopped to listen to them, without looking in their direction directly. He wanted to know what was worth saving, what was worth being shot for. Still without looking at the three girls, he walked to the creek as if to wash his hands in its icy waters.

"With child," said one of the girls. Her voice was sweet and happy.

"She is so blessed," another replied.

"But she had to marry out of the tradition," the other said. Her voice was as sweet and smooth as the other two.

It then occurred to him that his lover's voice was as sweet and as smooth when he first heard her speak to him. How much of that had he taken from her? As his fingers plunged into the muddy melt waters of the stream, he tried to think of only the coldness of the water and the invisible needles that pierced his submerged hands. *Will they torture me if I turn myself in?* he wondered. He was not afraid of torture, so that did not matter in the end. It was not a fear of torture that held him silent. Then what was it?

"At least she married," the first girl insisted.

Over the sound of the stream trickling over boulders, he could hear the clay dishes being stacked one upon the other. How many dishes had they come out to wash? What had they eaten on them, some figs and yogurt? Was the water as cold and piercing to their hands as it was to his? They were not talking about the cold water, but of warmer, gentler things. The hardest task his fingers had ever had was to pull a trigger or pick a lock. He didn't want to see more, so he lifted his hands out of the water and stood. After a few shakes, his hands were almost dry, but they were still chilled through to the bone. He walked slowly past the three girls and resumed his trek down the main street of the bazaar.

As the blood again started to flow in his fingers with the sensation of catching in the thorns of a rosebush, he knew the fate of Abadoun if he did not act, but it would mean revealing the location of the mythical eye of *Cheshman-e-Azadi*.

No agent of *Azadi* had ever done this; but then, no *Azadi* Eye had been caught in all the centuries the secret order had existed, so they remained a myth of the popular consciousness, at least at an official level. Since no one owned the popular consciousness completely, even here in Iran, no one could be certain of their existence. But the clandestine teachers of Kurdistan and Azerbaijan, with their precious smuggled blackboards and makeshift cellar classrooms knew better about the *Cheshman*. Their chalk came from somewhere. The contraband literature arrived

packed in the salt barrels somehow. Too many mullahs who had become corrupt died of “heart attacks” in too many little Iranian villages for the whole thing to be *just* a fairy tale in the minds of the officials. Even those three Kurdish girls washing their breakfast dishes in the creek knew of the Eye of the *Cheshman-e-Azadi*. The sons and daughters knew, even if their owners did not. His One Eye gave his story weight and might be enough to spare the town its fate, at the cost of his own life, perhaps.

Despite what he had told himself he would not do, he looked back at the three Kurdish girls by the stream. They were dressed in red mostly, but even from the distance he now stood from them, he could see the other colors of their traditional dresses. *Will they still be there when it comes?* he thought. *Maybe it would be nobler to die for the daughters of Kurdistan who I see right there down by the mountain creek than for a bird so few have seen. Certainly their voices are as sweet as the nightingale’s song.*

“A Man of the World”

Of learned men, and deeply Sophic things,
I know not, for I do not play those strings;
I am a man of the World, not the Lute,
My knowledge drips from what sweet Freedom sings.

Before his exile in Kurdistan, Ahmad Mehrdadi, town scribe and dry goods seller, had been a man of the world and an adherent to the principles of pragmatism. He had studied the major works of Persian, European, and Arabic classical literature, and had a fair knowledge of the political cogs that turned in the system of Reza Khan's government. Mohammed Mosaddeq himself asked him to leave a modest post as a teacher in a high school in Azerbaijan in order to come to the capital to assume a position in the Ministry of Education, but Mehrdadi declined, preferring, he said, to maintain his tenure at the tiny school where he taught.

When the short-lived Mosaddeq regime ended and Shah Mohammed Reza Pahlavi reassumed power after his brief exile, Mehrdadi stayed at his small school in Zangabad. He was offered promotions, but he always insisted on retaining his role as an educator rather than becoming an administrator. Even his eventual switch from high school teacher in Zangabad to college instructor in Tabriz was a calculated shift motivated more by a desire for a change of locale rather than ambition, since his boyhood had its roots in the noisy carpet bazaar of Tabriz.

Although his salary always remained modest because of his refusal to advance, Mehrdadi felt no remorse for his steadfastness, since he'd seen far too many ambitious eulogists before him climb up to the high offices amid the

social minarets only later to fall tumbling down into official disfavor.

"I am a teacher," he always said. "It is a modest living, but I will manage. I have only my books to buy."

At tea with his superior one day, he was asked again why he had refused his latest offer of promotion.

"Mr. Bandari," he said to his superior, "I live to teach facts and literature, not to administer the affairs of other teachers."

"But what of family?" Mr. Bandari asked. "What can you do for them on your salary?"

"You know that I am a bachelor," he replied. "My father and mother passed on before I moved to Zangabad. I have no one to be responsible for but myself, and in that respect, my salary is far more than sufficient to keep me in rice, eggplant, *kufteh*, and books. All the things necessary for an Azari man."

"But what of companionship, Mehrdadi? Your heart will ache for it one day, and you won't have the funds to cultivate it and watch it flourish, if you remain a poorly paid teacher."

"In essence, I am a practical man, Mr. Bandari. Philosophy and politics greater than that which I must bring into my classroom are above me. I do not have the depth of character required of a competent administrator."

"The self-effacement doesn't accord with your credentials, Mehrdadi."

"I beg you to understand," he returned.

"I take it that you won't accept a promotion this time either, then?" Mr. Bandari asked, rubbing his hands together in excitement.

"Indeed."

"Very well then, Mehrdadi!" Mr. Bandari said. "You are stubborn! But I like you too much too take offense in the face of your stubbornness. Perhaps your life will change so that you will have a wife to support, and the extra salary of an administrative position will appeal to your sense of decency towards the woman's need for a proper home."

“In such a circumstance, Bandari, my sensible nature would force me to agree with you. I confide to you as my friend, as well as my superior, that loneliness has been hard at my heart of late.”

“You are starting to feel the bite of bachelorhood.”

“Not so much the general bite of being a man, Bandari, but the specific bite of a particular lady who has caught my eye,” he confided.

“Just your eye at this point?” Mr. Bandari asked, resting his head in his hand for support.

“I know nothing of her other than what I see to be beauty on the outside. I haven’t even been close enough to hear her voice yet,” he admitted as he squirmed in his chair.

“Oh, do say *salam*, at least, Mehrdadi. I would be more than happy to have you get tangled up in the arms of a good woman, just to see you so much in debt like the rest of us that you’re forced to take on a promotion,” he laughed loudly.

“Until then the point is absurd, however, Bandari.”

Three months passed before Ahmad Mehrdadi saw Neda Khoshnevis at a staff meeting at the college and felt enough courage (or was it total fear?) in his heart to approach her. She was sitting alone in a far corner of the room, quietly taking notes during the presentation of a visiting educator from Mahabad. The striking flash of her huge eyes caught his attention, and once it had been caught, her general beauty held it there.

“You are striking,” he said.

“And you, Mr. Mehrdadi, are forward!” she retaliated with a wide smile.

“Haven’t you heard tell of me around here?” he asked.

“Anyone will tell you that I am nothing if not practical.”

“And is it practical to approach a lady you don’t know and compliment her so frankly?” she asked.

He cleared his throat. “I am not usually so bold, I admit. But I ask you, Miss Khoshnevis, how practical it would have been for me to ask you to sit over a small bite to eat with me, since I’ve already eaten this evening, and am

suffering from incredible indigestion as a result. Would torturing myself by stuffing more food down there just for a moment with you alone at a table been as practical as just getting to the point?"

She laughed at him, smiled, and said, "I suppose not. You are an *odd* one, I've heard said."

"I can't help myself," he told her. "Please forgive me. As I've said, I'm not usually this bold. How would I feel if I didn't ever say anything and let someone else step in and catch your attention, though, Miss Khoshnevis?"

A lonely man too familiar with late nights alone before an open book, Mehrdadi nonetheless found it within himself to become a regular and ardent caller at her parent's house, where she was still living. He knew from the start that his method was incredibly rough-hewn, but he felt deep in his heart upon seeing her at the meeting that a forward attitude had the best chance of succeeding at lifting his loneliness.

"I used to live down here," he said as they promenaded through the carpet bazaar one Friday. "My father was able to put me through university on the proceeds of his kiosk alone."

"You know," she said to him as they walked, "I have been having my doubts about the value of what we are doing at the college."

"Doubts? About our work? We are valuable," he said, holding tightly to her slender arm. She was far slighter than he, and he enjoyed showing her off to others, since he'd been a lonely, solitary man for too long. "How can you deny the value of a teacher? We teach many important things, and our students benefit greatly from it."

"We teach by rote," she said. "Surely you recognize that, Mehrdadi. Your own expertise in literature and contemporary history surely cannot leave you blind to that. You know the historical worthlessness of rote."

"We teach detailed material to disciplined minds," he replied, really more worried if she would later accept a kiss at her parents' door than what she was talking about.

“Rote. Here we are, in Azerbaijan, speaking what is essentially a foreign language to us. I myself am Kurdish, born and raised in Saqqez, but speaking Farsi, knowing Azari and Turkic dialects more than well enough, and yet I am ordered to teach in Farsi alone.”

“Things have been like this forever and a day in Iran, you know,” he tried to explain to her.

“I know the rote reply, Mehrdadi, but what value does our teaching have, if it is not in tune with the Azerbaijan and Kurdistan we see and hear everywhere around us?”

“Many great—”

“Of what worth is it to sit down with young Azari men and women and teach them useless rote skills contrived to put them in step with Western European and North American mores when, not so very long ago, the parents of these same children bowed at the feet of khans and *kaaks* and went about as nomads? Their language is the language of struggle, not the language of *our* pedagogy.”

He considered her words before replying, “And what are we to do? You know the laws we must obey. We are teachers, paid by the state to teach for the state. What can we do, other than teach that which we know, and what we are permitted to teach?”

“We can teach them the true language of struggle,” she replied.

“And what about what we *are* teaching them? Is a wholly illiterate Azari better than a half-literate one? What does it matter in what language he is literate? We must begin to build those foundations for any hope of change at all.”

“I already do it, Mehrdadi,” she interrupted him again. “I am not such an incrementalist.”

“You already do *what*, Miss Khoshnevis?” he asked.

“Take real action. I was just wondering if you’d be willing to take a look at my world and consider joining in.” She was quiet for a long time after those words.

He knew what she meant by the words “real action.” Soon, they arrived at her parents’ door and he looked into

her large, brown eyes and said, “I tell you what, Miss Khoshnevis: for one kiss—one simple kiss—I will look at what you have to show me, and consider it as honestly as my admittedly conservative and cautious eyes will allow. If I can see any practical value in it at...”

She leaned forward and kissed him on his lips, and he returned the kiss. “Meet me tomorrow night after five at the *Mostafa Kebab Teahouse*,” she said before entering the house and closing the door behind her.

He was too elated from the kiss to give her other words much thought. During the next day at the college he made mistakes in his presentation to his students since his mind was on the kissing lips of Neda Khoshnevis. After the work day passed, he hurried to the teahouse to meet her.

“Hello, Miss Khoshnevis,” he greeted her upon seeing her enter the place. “Now, what am I to see? Pray, make it quick, since the *kebab* stuck to my ribs.”

She led him to the back of the teahouse, down a long hallway, past what looked like a harem eunuch from ancient times in Arabia, and into a small, poorly lit room. Her large, brown eyes shone with a certain zeal that he had seen before in the eyes of fanatic soldiers marching in proud formation down the city streets.

Once in the dark room, she rolled back a large rug and exposed a cellar door. Just before opening the cellar door, she said, “Are you certain you want to know what I know? There is no turning back in your ideology once you’ve seen this.”

“I have already risked my life on the *kebab* presented here; I’ve little else to lose by jumping into such a damp dungeon.”

She flung open the cellar door and began to descend the narrow staircase. He followed her and soon they had walked some distance down a long, unlit hallway. At the very end was a door, and she opened it.

Behind the door was a cramped room with a blackboard up at the front. Unlike the students of his history and literature classes, these students did not have fine uniforms

or pens and paper to take notes. They wore instead the colorful garb of local peasants and committed to memory everything they had learned.

“This is a *classroom*? A place for learning?”

“Not the kind you’re used to,” she replied, walking to the front of the room and taking a piece of chalk.

“I don’t understand,” Mehrdadi said, turning his head about to get a better picture of the men and women all crammed into the stuffy cellar room. “This looks like a cheese cellar at best.”

“They used to keep wine in here!” one of the men said.

“Drink wine!” another called out.

“There are students here, Ahmad,” Miss Khoshnevis added, “but unlike the students we teach pro-Shah Persian history at the college—a history colored by the dogma of empty words—here in the cellar we teach the people of Azerbaijan their own rich history and language, unfettered by secret police and overeager informers masquerading as ambitious young students. There is no room for dogma or deceit here.”

“There’s not room for very much here!” one of the men hollered out.

“You are just an observer now, Ahmad,” she said. You will learn more about these things if you decide to teach the *real* language of our people.”

He gestured for them to leave and they quickly returned to the front of the teahouse. He’d been uneasy about being introduced to her world, but at the same time, he had already fallen in love with her and was unable to quickly dismiss her request to join her in this dangerous endeavor she put before him.

“Neda, I must admit that I cannot, without giving it much consideration, consent to joining this cause you yourself have espoused.” He took her arm and began leading her down the road. “I will promise you two things.”

“Yes?” she said, looking over at him with the eyes he so adored.

“First, I will not reveal what I know of this. You may rest assured that I know and saw nothing, either about the cellar or the people there. You hold a place in my heart that will not allow me to betray your trust in me, and besides that, it is right as a human being to stay silent on this matter. Second,” he added, “I will consider this all thoughtfully, rather than just pass it off with a wink. My interest in this matter has been ignited.”

She leaned over and kissed his cheek and they soon arrived at her house, where he returned her kiss with one of his own and left her standing at the door.

A week passed with Ahmad Mehrdadi deep in meditation about what he had learned from Neda Khoshnevis. He knew the price for what had been labeled treason to be imprisonment, exile, or death. He considered his own stain-free reputation as an educator during three tumultuous regimes and considered the consequences of staining that clean reputation. He took the matter to opium, and finally, he came to his decision: he was a practical man, but a lonely one. After the week passed, he returned to Neda’s parents’ house.

“Mrs. Khoshnevis,” he addressed Neda’s mother, “I wish to see your daughter, if I may.”

“Mr. Mehrdadi! Good to see you again!” she said with a smile. “Neda-*aziz*, Mr. Mehrdadi is here to see you, *Mama!*” She then disappeared back into the house.

“Neda,” he said when she finally arrived, “I have given the matter much consideration.”

“Yes? And?”

“I wonder if my yearning for normalcy hasn’t been completely obliterated by my yearning for you,” he admitted.

“I’m glad I have some effect on you, Ahmad,” she returned, grasping his hand and caressing it with her own.

“It’s no small responsibility for me to lurk about in cellars at night. The repayment for this could be imprisonment, or even death, as you know.”

“Yes,” she replied. He looked intently at her to see her resolve and saw that her eyes were as steely with determination to stick to her cause as they were soft with her love for him.

“You have been willing to face this, should you be discovered,” he added. “Brave you are, Neda.”

Her eyes lit up with a zealous flame again and he knew for sure that he loved her. “Yes, Ahmad-*aziz*.”

Finally, he told her, “I will join you with your blackboards in the cellars, but on one condition.”

“Condition? I don’t know if the other members of the group will be too—”

“Not a condition for *them*,” he explained. “A condition for *you*.”

“Me?” Confusion covered her face.

“Yes, a condition for you,” he repeated.

“If my affection for you permits,” she consented. “Go on with the condition, then.”

“I admit that I wouldn’t entirely be doing it for the people and their movements, or entirely for freedom. Actually, I’d be doing it for slavery.”

“Slavery? What kind of slavery?”

“I believe it was for a kiss that you bought my promise to come and take a look at your world?”

Neda smiled at this. “You told me you’d come and look if I kissed you. A small price to pay, since I’d wanted to kiss you so badly anyway.”

“I would have kissed you soon regardless. Well, then, for such a monumental, life altering promise as this one, Neda-*jaan*, I’ll ask something a little more consequential than a kiss—though your lips have been in my thoughts ever since.”

“What do you want from me? If it’s mine to give, then I shall.”

“As I’ve said, I am a practical man. I feel I need you. As set as I am in my life and ways, you would be my main motivation in becoming a rebel. Marry me at your earliest convenience, Neda, and I will gladly teach beside you both

at the college and in the damp cellars of teahouses. I will for no less a promise. Marry me.”

“I will marry you,” she said, holding him close to her.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

He lit a cigarette but it did nothing to calm his nerves so it was soon smoldering on the frozen earth beneath his boots. He was passing by her again. This time he dared to glance over at her and saw her kneeling over her large tray of rice, picking out the stones. He wanted to call out: “It doesn’t matter how long you pick at that rice, Leili! If I don’t—”

He didn’t call out. Her name wasn’t really Leili, but she was there for his comfort, the passing Majnoun, as he had said, so she might as well be Leili—there for his nights of loneliness and insanity. Had he bolted over to her and tried to drag her out of Abadoun with him, to save her if no one else, he would be breaking one of the principle rules of *Azadi* to do so: *Secrecy comes before personal loyalty*. He knew that she could see him from under her veil, that he might have made her heart lighter for having looked her way, despite the oaths.

What were the what now seemed to him empty oaths of *Azadi*, anyway? The *Cheshman-e-Azadi* had been formed as an order to give God back to His people by undermining corrupt government by any means possible. They were a brotherhood of assassins and smugglers who recruited university students with half-knowledge and half-ideologies. He’d seen how many in his career with them? Seven at most? Omar at his teahouse, her in his bed at the musty caravanserai as he passed through, a few others with supplies in Saqqez, the charming one at the Sorbonne who had enlisted him.

He knew that other, less sinister orders existed. There were the key keepers of the Negel Mosque near Sanandaj to the southeast. These key keepers guarded the Kuffi Koran in their sacred mosque by giving the key to the mosque to a

different keeper each night. The keeper himself was the only one who knew to whom the key was next passed. Their secrecy revealed the faithfulness and solidarity of the villagers of Negel, whereas his secrecy might mean the death of all the villagers of Abadoun. Certainly there were other, more secret orders with far nobler purposes than *Azadi* that he could have joined.

He knew his fellow agents them from their hidden tattoo, their Eye. They could show him theirs, and he could show them his, but only after they were sure, and when they were alone. Never more than two eyes at a time in any one room. Home many hundred rules were there to this game?

Yes, game. It was like a great, facetious game at times—a game played by intellectuals, nostalgia mongers, and fairy tale writers who didn't want to give up their precious Persia. Always a game, and always with human cards. Always with one Eye being cut out to save the other. He was to kill himself if found out so that the others wouldn't be plucked from the greater socket and they were to kill themselves rather than betray him. The very stuff of a thousand and one tales.

Tales. The tale she had told him at her smooth bosom the night before had already rewritten itself in his clouded mind, becoming a terrible thing, so that he wondered if she would even recognize the very same tale of Ali Shamlou in its new form.

“The Tale of Mohammed Ali Shamlou”

Tomorrow? Ah! what can I know of Her;
You must know I am no philosopher!
But, since you've asked, I'll herein risk a guess:
Tomorrow will be as Yesterdays were.

There once was, there once was not; other than God, there was no one. Many, many years ago, when the Iran's rivers flowed red with the blood of many men, and the wailing of mothers could be heard from Tabriz to Bandar-Abbas, in the time after the fall of the King of Kings, there lived a mullah high in the mountains.

Appointed was he to select from the young men of his town those able to stand and fight against the enemies of the new king. Heavy was his burden as he would walk down the cobblestone streets of the village, pointing out those men who would be sent off to fight.

Many mothers would throw themselves at his feet, begging to keep their sons at home, listing many causes for their supplication: the most important being that women, children, and old men could neither tend properly to the flocks, nor till the soil.

“We are tilling the sacred soil of *jihad!*” he would holler at them before pointing to another man. “God will fill your bellies and the ground will support your weight!”

Months passed in the village thus. Mothers and fathers, overcome with fear at the mere sight of the mullah's decisive pointing finger, sometimes packed their sons' most useful belongings into sacks and sent their boys out into the mountains to fend for themselves, that they might one day come back to the village to rebuild, should ever the war come to a conclusion.

One such boy, Mohammed Ali Shamlou, resisted his mother's pleas to leave:

"Mother, I must stay and tend to you, for you are sick, and will not be able to care for yourself when I am gone," he said to her one cold, starry night.

"Ali, sweet Ali," his mother said, tears pouring from her eyes as swiftly as the waters of the rivers, "you must save your own life before Mullah picks you. Perhaps I will die without you, Ali, but I would rather that you fled swiftly into the mountains than be buried under a hill near some distant battlefield."

Ali could not obey his mother and stayed instead to tend to her and his family's affairs. The time came when it was his turn. The finger of Mullah pointed at him in the streets, but he would not be taken. With all speed, and without provisions, he fled into the mountains to the east and made his way in the woods, where he encountered many wondrous things.

"Young man," a wolf said to him as he watered at a small creek. "Where art thou going? Hast thou no sense, that thou should'st stray from thy hamlet into these woods, so late in the year, when the bushes give no berries, and the fish are passing hard to catch?"

At first, Ali, like any other, was very afraid of the wolf, but when he looked closely, he could see that the beast was not poised to attack him.

"Wolf, sir, I assure you that by no choice of my own am I here, dining with the beasts, living like one myself." He decided it would be polite to offer the wolf some of the small fish he had speared with a small stick, and the wolf eagerly accepted the offer.

"Then, art thou a fugitive, sent into these woods in exile? I have heard tales of these, but it has been many a year since such things be done."

"I was to be sent to fight in a battle that was none of mine," Ali replied. "Were I not to come out here, I would have most certainly died in this battle, and my family

would die with me, for I am the last, and the only one who can continue our line.”

The wolf was for a long time silent, but then said to Ali, “Then, I shall assume that thou wishest to find the others like thee, those who also fled into these hills, so that thou may’st run with the pack of thine own kind?”

“You know of the others like me?”

The wolf looked from left to right. “Sir, thou hast kindly given me what remained of thine only meal, and thou hast been passing polite with me. Indeed, I have seen others like you in these hills. They gather together where only we beasts can find them. But, if I am to assist thee to their fold, I ask of thee one promise.”

Ali begged the wolf to insist upon any favor, since no price was too great to find others in his predicament, so that he may have brotherhood with his fellow Kurds.

“I am an old wolf and not as keen in the hunt as once I was. My swiftness is less swift, my keen less keen, and my sharp less sharp. When thou returnest to the village, when thou makest thine home comfortable again, and livest off the lamb that thou herd’st, would’st thou yearly leave one slaughtered lamb at this very spot near the creek for me, that I might taste the meat of the lamb, as in my youth? Should it ever be that thou returnest so.”

Ali agreed that he would honor this promise.

“Promises in this domain are not to be taken lightly, thou should’st know. Should’st thou not abide, fine sir, I will, with mine own armies come into thy hamlet and feast on the youngest and the oldest of you!”

Ali shuddered at the thought of it but knew that he would die without the wolf’s help. “It is my solemn oath that I will slaughter one lamb every year for you when I return to my village, old wolf.”

“Then grab hold of the fur at my neck and let me lead thee to thine own pack.”

Ali did as he was told. After many miles of walking in the thick brush, the wolf stopped, turned to him, and said:

“Thou goest not far from here, and thou art with thine own.”

Ali ran quickly, and soon found himself at an encampment of men like himself, some whom he knew from the village in the days of the King of Kings.

He trained in the arts of fighting, foraging, and soon learned to survive the cold with little more than a thin shirt on his back. Many months passed thus, and he became very wishful to see his family and friends.

“I have seen you weeping,” a nightingale said to Ali from the trees as he gathered roots for the others.

“I am sad. I want to go home,” Ali replied.

“I can take you home.”

“I would be killed if I were to return.”

The nightingale sang its song, not seeming to hear Ali’s reply. “I know what is in the hearts of men, Ali.”

“You know my name?”

“I know you. I know Mullah. I will sing a song in his ear, and you will not be in danger of his wrath. He is old and will forgive you if I sing it so. Trust me.”

“And what must I promise you in return for your kind act?” Ali asked, remembering his promise to the wolf, and wondering what the nightingale would demand of him.

“A nightingale’s song is free,” the bird replied before flying away.

Many nights later, the bird returned and whispered into Ali’s ear, “The road is clear for you. Be off!”

Ali, knowing that the others would not let him go back, lest he be tortured and reveal their hideout, waited for the right moment when they were all asleep, and left without taking his things with him.

Soon, he had found his way back to the village. Upon hearing of his return, Mullah ordered a great feast for the safe return of one of the sons of the village. Ali’s mother, very ill, was brightened by his return and soon returned to health. The year passed, and though the mullah sent many other men off to be soldiers, he ever overlooked Mohammed Ali Shamlou.

Ali was so amazed at his safe return into the life of the village that he entirely forgot his promise to the wolf. When the year had passed, he heard the wolves howling in the mountains, and it was this that reminded him of his oath.

In a terror, hoping it was not too late to live up to his oath, Ali slaughtered one of his fattest lambs and carried it high into the hills. He found the creek and waited.

The wolf appeared at the creek with its pack.

"Foolish boy!" said the wolf. "Hast thou so little honor that thou would'st ignore a promise made to a gentle wolf?"

"Sir Wolf," Ali implored the beast, "I was so caught up with my life, so happy to have returned to my ailing mother, that I forgot my promise to you. But, here I am now."

"Not on time. Moreover, boy, how was it that thou camest to be back in thine own village, when all the others remain high in the hills? What favor hast thou that none of them have? Wolves are honorable, and travel in packs, and will have none to do with traitors. Be frank, thou art back there *how*?" The wolf bared its fangs, and although it was old, Ali could see that he was no match for it and would certainly be killed with one jump at the throat.

"A nightingale charmed the mullah to forgive me and let me back into the town," Ali said, trembling terribly.

"That one nightingale should say unto thee: 'Go, betray thine fellows, run now and leave them behind,' thou should'st listen?" said the wolf, again bearing its fangs.

"I saw no harm in it," Ali stuttered.

"That thy word means naught is quite clear, boy. I saved thy life here out in the woods by leading thee to thine own kind. A nightingale, most sly of all singers, charmed thee into betraying thy pack. But, what of thy promise? At the very least, even a stray wolf, even a loner, will carry his lamb to the king of the wolves once a year, as promised. Did this nightingale charm thee so that thou would'st also have thine own beloved hamlet die by our teeth? All those

young and old that thou may'st for but one *year* only be again with them?"

"I have the lamb—"

"Late!" the wolf growled. The other wolves with him all bared their teeth, and Ali felt that he would surely die.

"Please, just take me, not the villagers," Ali begged the wolf. "How fair is it to take the town, the women, the children, because a foolish boy made a promise when wet and nearly starved?"

"Ah, yes! Nearly starved wert thou, and also was I. Even I have a sense of fairness. I remember thy kindness to me, too, boy, not just thy present treachery," the wolf replied. "When I was hungry thou gavest me half thy catch, though thou wert passing hungry, too. For this, I promise that no wolf shall harm thy townsfolk as long as I shall live."

(And here is where Leili's tale ended and Majnoun's began:

"Oh, noble Wolf!" Ali exclaimed. "I am so—"

"Let me finish! I said no *wolf*! When thou return'st to thy hamlet from here, boy, thou wilt find no man, woman, or child alive."

"But how?" Ali screamed. "You are all here, with me. And you said...."

The old wolf turned away as did his followers. When he was almost out of Ali's sight, he turned his head back and howled:

"That a simple creature of the sky should charm thee into betraying thine own kind twice over, thy treachery shall be repaid from the sky, Mohammed Ali Shamlou."

And so it was, and was not, many, many years ago, that when Mohammed Ali Shamlou returned to his beloved village, he found everyone stone dead from a poisonous cloud sent into the sky by the enemies just across the border. So torn was he by the horrific sight that he threw himself from a cliff situated high in the mountains, far from sight of the village he had once called his happy home.)

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

All for the insane *status quo* of these uncounted mythical creatures known only as the Eyes of Freedom he would keep his tongue and let the common folk of a village die? Is that what the first Sufi scholar who had founded the secret society of assassins, body smugglers, and freedom fighters had intended when he'd formulated the tenets of secrecy that nailed his tongue to the roof of his mouth now, four hundred years later?

He was soon at his car door, fumbling in his pocket for his key. He would get in, and drive either left or right. To the mullah's office with wild tales of death from the sky, or on to rescue one political. One tomato. One Bolbol. Thirty lashes. Three hundred Kurds: peasants who could neither read nor write. They would not lead a counterrevolution.

Outside one of the village homes that overlooked his car, he could see a family of Kurds sitting and talking. The five of them were sitting on a raised clay and straw platform that served as their outdoor salon, even in the colder months, just so long as there was no snow on the ground. One of the men, too old to fight, held a small girl to his chest, while a woman across from him held tightly onto a boy. Beside the old man sat an older man, possibly his father. All sat cross-legged. They managed to force a smile over his way, and he smiled back.

The old man in black had beside him a large round platter that has been propped up against the rough mud wall. He and the other man were on a tattered animal skin with a bowl of yogurt in front of them. The woman had before her an assortment of tin pots and pans. She had what looked from the distance like a baby bottle in her hand.

None of these people would head a provisional government. If the gas burned their eyes out at prayer, no

country or consciousness would be blinded by it. As for his friends, the two eyes, they would be replaced. Another tea vendor could be found. Another girl to pick stones from the dinner rice, another Leili to comfort the latest passing Majnoun. Could this family of weather-worn Kurds sitting out on the dusty yellow platform in the cold be replaced?

One key. He turned it. The car didn't want to start. The car didn't want to leave. The car seemed to have a plan greater and more noble than his own. He turned the key again and was successful at starting it this time. He glanced over at the family again. One of the children, the boy in the woman's arms, had been startled by the rare sound of an engine starting, and was looking at him with the intense curiosity of youth. Perhaps there was enough curiosity in those young eyes that something would grow into—

The engine sucked in the petrol and roared. The villagers didn't have cars; they had mules. He didn't belong among them. His world had become separate from the world he had sworn to protect through subterfuge.

The Iraqis would gas the town at noon, and then come into it that night, when they couldn't be seen, only to find that it was populated by bending, praying peasants and their beasts of burden—no cars, no rifles, no *Pasdars*, unless they were on their way to Baneh by way of Abadoun and happened to be caught in the mist. The Iraqis would kick over a few bazaar stands, spill out their overripe tomatoes and half rotten eggplants, and perhaps pick twenty useless *tuman* out of a well-fed, battered boy's torn pocket. They would wonder at an old shop keeper's bloodied cane. And then they would go home and play cards in stinking Baghdad teahouses and brag about their victories over the heretic Shi'ite warriors of Abadoun. That there were no warriors and that the Kurds were devout Sunnis like themselves would make no difference to the reports.

He put the car into gear. Perhaps he would be in Baneh by the time it hit, on his way to Saqqez. Sent to Teheran for the prisoner. One Bolbol. One tomato. One bullet is all it would take to put out his Eye tomorrow if they did believe

him. Or he'd die in the mullah's makeshift cellar jail if they didn't and stayed on in the town.

The villagers on the road moved away to let the car pass, just as they had moved to let the soldiers' truck through. They did not know him well, except for his overnight stays at the caravanserai. His accent was thick. They did not care to have him around—he was not a Kurd. Very soon he was at an intersection that had been intended for use by mules, not cars.

Left—mullah. Right—Saqqez.

It made him think of a poem that he could no longer remember the words to. An American had written it and he had studied it during his University days in Europe. A path in the woods. The path taken, the path not taken. *How much are tomatoes worth in America?* he wondered. He knew how much they were worth in France, where he'd studied. He asked himself what he had done all that studying for in the first place, since it had no power in his life; it was emptiness from his past, leaving his future emptier in turn. Something he would take with him to Sweden or wherever his refugee "retirement" uprooted him.

A woman who was well advanced into her pregnancy walked across the rock-strewn road in front of him. The sight of her heaviness held him in indecision a while longer. Maybe there was nobody in Abadoun *now* who would lead the counterrevolution, but would *she* give birth to another nightingale—one to take the place of Bolbol—should he save her? Would her child one day be in a prison, waiting to be rescued by what amounted to no more than body smugglers with self-attached labels of heroism? If she died at noon with the rest, who would know what her child would have become?

Azadi was to serve God, not play at being God.

Perhaps this child would grow up to lead Iran to a democratic Islam, but it could just as easily be the next town mullah—her womb was not particular and did not care what it produced, just so long as it did indeed bear fruit. A son would make her happy, peasant or mullah,

infidel or Faqih, and a daughter might also, were she to go on and give a grandson to her mother.

“For a Husband from Shiraz”

Our daughters once we sold for greater price,
And in those days, a beautiful girl thrice
Her weight in figs, wine, rose water was worth—
And now we sell her for a cup of rice.

You awoke when the cock crew. Your bladder was full and he was kicking it. He was strong and would make a good soldier for Islam, like his father. Bahram was sleeping in the adjoining room, away from you because he did not like the way you tossed and turned in your sleep. You arose, dressed, and waddled into the tiny kitchen to prepare your husband's breakfast. It was then that you noticed that there was no honey, and you knew he would be angry at you for serving his bread without it.

You quickly covered yourself with your *chador* and headed for the marketplace. The only shop that sold honey would not yet be open, you knew, but you also knew that Bahram would rise soon and that he would demand breakfast as soon as he limped out of his bedroom and saw you. You knew that he would patiently wait for you if you were not there but would not be so patient with you if you were, and you wanted to avoid another chiding from him.

You did not look about as you hurried down the road, so you did not at first see the other woman you collided with. It did not take long for you to notice, however, that she was not pregnant. You did not envy her at all, since you recognized immediately that she was the unmarried daughter of Ahmad Mehrdadi, the shopkeeper. Unlike you, she did not have a husband from Shiraz, or from anywhere, for that matter.

You could tell that she was trying to figure out who you were, since she looked you up and down. "I am stupid!" she exclaimed.

Pity filled your heart for the shopkeeper's daughter, since she might as well have been barren; the men who remained in Abadoun after so many months of conscription were not fit to marry anyone, let alone the daughter of Ahmad Mehrdadi, the man to whom everyone brought their important written affairs to be read aloud. He was an educated man, with an educated wife, and a daughter more educated than any other daughter of the village, and yet she was unmarried.

"God is merciful," you said to her. You tipped your head in her direction and then continued on your way to find the honey. Your son was still kicking at your full bladder, and you were angry that you forgot to relieve yourself before leaving the house. It would have to wait until you returned.

The tiny store fronts of the bazaar quickly passed you by until you were in front of Mr. Mehrdadi's store. He had nothing that you wanted to buy, but you wanted to apologize for bumping into his daughter. When you saw him sitting inside, laughing to himself over something he was reading in one of his many books, you decided it was best to pass by him, since it would be rude to interrupt such an educated man from his studies.

A hand tapped your right shoulder and you turned to face whoever it was who wanted your attention. It was the wife of Ghassemi the farmer. She had a dozen eggs in her basket, and you remembered that you had promised to trade her some needlework for them.

"*Salam*, Mrs. Ghassemi," you said, trying to remember where you had put the needlework at home. Your son seemed to be taking all of your better memories away from you.

"*Al-ekom-os-salam*," she returned with a curtsy. "I see you do not have the needlework with you now, but I will take your word that it is done." She gave you the eggs.

“You must believe me when I say that my mind wanders!” you said, slapping yourself on the side of your head. “I have completed the needlework. It is sitting in at my home, ready for you. I should have brought it with me.”

“I was not barren in my day!” she laughed. “I know how the mind can wander when a child is forming in the kiln, dear girl!”

You knew that her three sons had long since been killed while in Khoramshahr on duty. How proud she must have been to have heard that God had chosen her sons as martyrs for the Faith. Only three weeks after the news of their brave deaths reached Abadoun did the message come that a husband had been found for you in Shiraz.

“How is Mr. Zamanzadeh coming along under your care?” the old lady asked. “I’m sure the eggs will help him recover a bit of his strength. A good regimen of eggs and lamb stew will bring the strength back into the worst off. Though the echo of the shelling scares the chickens and makes the eggs runny.”

“What he really needs is a bit of air,” you said. “He isn’t one to come out of the house much, you know.” Perhaps you had said too much, you thought, and she would chastise you for criticizing your husband’s habits.

“Of course,” she said, rubbing her hands together and looking down, “one cannot expect too much at first from one who has given a leg for the Imams. Just put an extra egg in front of him with his meals, and he’ll be well on his way to keeping pace with the rest of us.”

You thought about the stump that was once called a leg, and you felt pity for your husband. “You are right,” you agreed. “Mr. Zamanzadeh has given much for the Imams,” you echoed her words. “One cannot expect too much in the way of his coming out for air. I’ll try more eggs.”

She looked at you for a long time, making you wonder what she could be thinking. “Would you like to come over to my house?” she asked. “I’ve some baby clothes that...” She stopped herself. “Well, you understand.”

You did understand. She had an assortment of baby clothes that she would never be able to give to her grandchildren, since her sons all were martyred at Khoramshahr before marrying and raising families of their own. One of them, the oldest and most handsome, had asked your father's permission to court you, but he was sent to war down in the southern province of Khozestan before the courtship could begin.

"I have to fetch a bit of honey," you replied. "Mr. Zamanzadeh would be cross with me if I returned too late and without honey for his breakfast. I do not want to be a trouble to you, in any case."

"Oh, no!" she exclaimed. "No trouble! Come with me, and I will give you a cup of our honey. Will a cup satisfy Mr. Zamanzadeh?"

"I'm sure it would," you said. You signaled with your hand for her to lead on.

You were soon at the tiny door of their house. Mrs. Ghassemi kept it unlocked, as did most of the villagers. "I'll have to remember to have Mr. Ghassemi put a proper bolt on the door. I heard news that bandits ransacked the Shahpouri family last night and took everything they owned. With the war going on, these thieves and bandits reckon they can just reign over us poor country folk like khans. These aren't quiet times at all, I assure you, Mrs. Zamanzadeh."

"Please," you said, "I would not at all be offended if you called me Fatimeh." You entered her home, following closely behind her. You could smell cooked rice and saffron in the air and wondered if your husband would be awake yet.

"Fatimeh it is, then," she said. "I should know better than to play *ta'arof* with you, really. Your mother and I were friends for many years before...."

"Father explained everything to me a long time ago," you said. "Arguments happen, even between longtime friends. Don't feel awkward with me because of it."

She led you to the kitchen and presented a seat to you. “Well, yes, they do, but I’ve always been ashamed that your mother and I never had a chance to settle our arguments before the fever took her.”

“We’ll all meet our Maker one day,” you comforted her, “and, God willing, we will all have ample opportunity to settle our accounts with Him. In the meantime, our accounts with one another must be kept in good order.”

She looked at you, slowly removing her heavy, black *chador*. “You have wisdom beyond your years,” she said. Her face was wrinkled, but she hid her age well.

You decided to keep your veil on, since you knew you really could not stay with Mrs. Ghassemi for very long. “A good wife is nothing if not always striving for God’s wisdom,” you said. “She will never achieve it, of course, but she should strive for it, nonetheless. There is no harm in trying to be as prudent as He will allow us.”

“Speaking of which!” she exclaimed, snapping her fingers and burning in the cheeks like a freshly lit candle. “The clothes! I almost forgot about them!” She rose, left the room, and returned a few moments later with a large, delicately inlaid wooden box. “How wise could you say *I* was if I were to forget the things?”

“That is a lovely box,” you said.

“My grandmother made it,” Mrs. Ghassemi replied proudly. “She was very skilled with her hands and often sold the boxes she inlaid whenever they would venture up in Mahabad. This one she gave to my mother, and my mother gave it to me in turn. I never had any daughters, you see, and cannot have any granddaughters for obvious reasons. I’d even give it to my sons, to keep up the tradition as best I could, if I had any sons left. God has willed that this box be buried with me, I suppose. The Imposed War has taken more than our sons, it seems.”

She looked melancholy with the box in her hands and you wanted to say something, but you could not find the right words to offer her. “I know God will give me a son,” you said simply. “A soldier, like his father.”

What Mrs. Ghassemi said next surprised you. “If only my sons had been farmers like *their* father, instead of soldiers.”

“But, Mrs. Ghassemi,” you chided, “surely you are proud to have been the mother of three martyrs. If not for his injury, Mr. Zamanzadeh would still be fighting for the Imams. Are you questioning God’s ways?”

“Fatimeh, I do not question God and His wisdom; I am a simple Kurdish woman, with no place among scholars, to be sure,” she began, “but then again, we are all—every one of us—*Kurds*, which makes us by blood wandering shepherds and farmers, not Islamic intellectuals in this region at least. Mr. Ghassemi’s forefathers were neither *sheikh* nor *agha*, neither *khan* nor *mullah*.”

“Most of us haven’t forefathers as those,” you reminded her. “We serve God as our lot permits.”

“Indeed. My point. How many hundreds of years have the Ghassemis farmed their forefathers’ soil, for all tradition to end with a single bombardment and a handful of shrapnel? Common folk need common sons to till the common soil, to feed God’s children.” She opened the box and started sorting through its contents. “If God wants to end the humble but ancient Ghassemi line with a hiccup, I will not question His wisdom, dear Fatimeh, but had my sons been farmers like their father, the Ghassemis would be farmers and shepherds for many generations yet to come. As it is, the Ghassemis are like a candle wick, waiting for a wind to come and blow them out in a whim.”

“Doesn’t your brother or your husband’s brother have any sons who can carry on?” you asked.

“Mr. Ghassemi’s brothers have all died. My only brother is blind and has no children. We are the last.”

“And what of the Foundation for the Disinherited? Surely there is a sizable pension for you and your husband on account of your sons’ service to the Imams. My Zamanzadeh receives a monthly—”

“The pension I receive, Fatimeh, will not rise up out of the bank in Teheran where it sits and till the soil, will it?”

You nodded no.

“Will the faces on the money smile for me? Will the soldiers on these new bills they give us father grandchildren for me?”

You nodded no again.

“Does Mr. Zamanzadeh—God preserve him, for he was nearly martyred himself—gain any use of his lost leg by means of *his* veteran’s pension? All the men on the bills have two legs, Fatimeh. What do they know of Mr. Zamanzadeh’s torment? Pensions are nothing!”

You nodded again, not really knowing if you agreed or disagreed, but you were caught up in her words and your ears stung you.

“As for the pension Mr. Ghassemi and I receive, it will be left to the poor of Abadoun as an endowment administered by a close friend of my husband. Poor families like the Shahpouris need it more than we will after we’re gone. They have a son to keep their line going. They were robbed of even the little they owned last night.”

“I understand *zakat* as well as anyone. If they were robbed, that *is* a shame. They may not be from this village originally, but they are our own now. Perhaps I should put aside something from Mr. Zamanzadeh’s war pension for the Shahpouris, too.”

She pulled out a tiny girl’s bonnet. “But anyway, Fatimeh dear, we are talking of things best left unsaid, aren’t we?”

“Yes, unpleasant things are better left in silence.”

“Except at funeral processions.”

“Except then.”

“Here we go, then. This was mine when I was a baby. My mother saved it for my daughter. You can never know these things in advance.” She held out a lovely, colorful blanket for you.

“I want a—”

“Now, now, dear girl, you know God hides it away inside a woman to make her worry. Boy, girl, who knows except Him?”

“But, I’m not at all worried, Mrs. Ghassemi. I *feel* it is a—”

“And here you are talking about not belittling God, Fatimeh! Where were you when he spoke to Abraham, when he spoke to the Prophet? I know better than to second guess God.”

“Indeed, we ought not,” you agreed with her, nodding your veiled head.

“It was not in His plan that I should have a daughter, any more than it was in His plan that I should know that when I was a freshly married maiden, was it?”

It made your heart sour to accept anything so meaningful and laden with family tradition from her and you wanted instead to leave her house as quickly as you could, but you had no polite excuse. “Surely, these clothes are too precious to be giving away,” you finally said. “They are so carefully made. Don’t squander them on me, please—they are your treasures. They are so carefully made.”

She began to laugh so hard that you thought she might fall over. You could not understand what had made her react like that, until she at last spoke.

“Fatimeh! You are not as wise as I thought! Don’t you hear what you just said from your own lips? Surely my sons, and my neighbors’ sons, and the son or daughter that God has given you—surely they are more carefully made than the most precious box or most skillfully embroidered bonnet, and yet, still we give them away happily to God and His Imams, to be smashed like clay and unraveled by vultures on the battlefield.”

She hit one hand so hard onto the other that the crack almost made you relieve your bladder as you sat there. After a bit of concentration, you were again in control of yourself. She calmed down and continued to speak to you.

“We are Kurds, one and the same, girl. Our families go back many years. We gave too much for the Mahabad Republic before your time, and for the many years of stifling oppression of Shah.” She sighed deeply, closing her

eyes so tightly that you could see the pain in her expression. It made your heart beat faster and he began kicking at you again.

“I—”

“Take the clothes, dear child, so you do not insult me with your rejection of my good things. They were not too good for me when my mother offered them to me. Boukhara and Samarqand they’re not, but they’re mine to give, and mine to squander as I will. We agreed not to play *ta’arof*, Fatimeh.”

Her smile extended widely and you could not refuse her supplication; you stretched out your hand and took the gifts that she offered. Finally, she had no more clothes to give and it was time to return home before Bahram awoke.

As you hurried home, you passed an intersection where normally only beasts of burden would pass. A quick glance over your shoulder yielded a view of a car. You had wanted your husband in Shiraz to have a car just like this. Or, if not like this man’s car, perhaps larger. You had not seen many cars come to Abadoun, and admitted to yourself that you really had no idea how large they could be, but your dreams of life in Shiraz had never included donkeys and horses—just cars of one kind or another.

Soon the car turned at the intersection and was on its way. You were not much later again in front of your own home with Bahram’s honey and Mrs. Ghassemi’s precious things. You opened the door and your question was soon answered. Bahram was awake.

“I see you’ve come back at last,” he said, his voice still strange to your ears and nothing like you had imagined the Shirazi accent would be. He did not speak Kurdish at all, and you were obliged to struggle with what Persian you had been taught during Shah’s time just to understand his words.

“Yes, my husband,” you replied. If you reached the kitchen quickly enough, you reasoned, he would not suspect that you had been out looking for honey for his bread. “I remembered that I had some baby clothes to pick

up from Mrs. Ghassemi, and that she had eggs for us. She says you should take more eggs with your meals to build your strength, so you can get out and about in the mountain air."

You were almost at the kitchen door when he said, "Her sons' baby things, then?"

You didn't want to reply but felt obliged by the prying tone of his voice. "Girl things for the daughters she never had. She was quite insistent," you almost apologized to him. "I told her it was useless, since I'm carrying a son, but—"

"O Fatimeh-*aziz*, pray to Almighty God you have a daughter," Bahram said, his voice for the first time since you'd heard it not full of anger or hatred or spite. "I want a daughter, Fatimeh. Not a son. A daughter."

"Zamanzadeh?" you gasped, one hand on the kitchen door handle, the other holding the things. "A girl? And how will she fight for the Twelve Imams, Zamanzadeh? How will a daughter do that?"

His eyes clouded over with what you knew to be hatred and spite again, and he returned, "Why, it's quite clear! She'll pray to God to get out of her cave of a village, at any cost. She'll marry a war amputee on a State-sponsored plan."

"Bahram, please, I—"

"Then, she'll find out she's staying in the cave instead of leaving it. She'll bed with the half-man. I'm not as stupid as you think I am, Fatimeh—I know what's been going on in your head. I know what you were thinking when we were in our wedding bed, with all your romantic girlhood dreams of escape to Shiraz as broken as your hymen. I know what—"

"Bahram! God's mercy on my ears! Such bawdy talk!"

"Anyway, as to your question, woman, she'll serve the Imams on her back, pushing out soldier-makers for generations to come."

"Zamanzadeh! Please!" You were almost in tears but held them inside you.

“In other words, Fatimeh-*jaan*, our daughter shall fight for the Imams just as you have. And better that than the way I have,” he added, pointing at what was once a sound leg. “Better a girl than a boy, I’d say, I would.

“Definitely better! Just look at this God-forsaken village. One man can serve the Imams just until he’s shot. One woman can serve the Imams across generations, Fatimeh-*jaan*.”

You were shaking and you could feel the stream of urine running down your leg a bit. You wanted to storm out of the room but knew he would be angrier with you if you did that and stayed instead to hear more.

“Now that we’ve figured out all that, where’s my bread with honey and my tea?”

You turned away from him and entered the kitchen first to clean yourself and then to make ready, cursing in your heart all that you had given for your husband from Shiraz.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

He turned right and went on to Saqqez by way of the road that first passed through Baneh.

Several miles along his bumpy journey, he came to the overturned army truck. Four soldiers' bodies had been piled up naked at the side of the road and the others remained where they had fallen. He knew they had been ambushed, their weapons taken, and that there was the real risk that the rebels who had ambushed them were still up in the cliffs, waiting for another target. He continued on without stopping.

Sitting next to him in the car was the one overripe tomato the old man had given him as payment for grabbing the boy. The old man must not have noticed in his anger that the boy had had a chance to take a tiny bite out of it. Had he known, he certainly would have found another, more suitable reward for him among the others in the pile.

“The Song of the Nightingale”

I woke and peered through three hundred iron bars,
And saw above how many million stars—
The bulbul sang like a mad muezzin,
And the lights fell down like the sons once ours.

Ali Nasser folded his tiny prayer mat out before him. His fighter jet, *El-Bolbol*, awaited him, prepared by a small crew of select men. After his prayers had been said, he rolled up his mat and gave it to Muhammad el-Gabbana and said, “Keep this, should I not return.”

You are so blessed to be going on this mission. “I will,” Muhammad replied. *I will keep it safe. God keep you safe, Ali Nasser.*

Nasser slowly ascended the ladder to the cockpit and prepared himself for take-off. The attendants watched him enter the cockpit and thought that he was a brave man to be so willing to fly such a mission.

If only I didn’t need such thick glasses, one of them complained to himself. If only my heart could take the acceleration, the other thought in turn. If only God will keep me steady to my mission, Nasser prayed still.

If only she would look at me, an old man far away thought. She would see I love her.

This eggplant is nearly rotten to the core, the old man’s customer noticed to herself. “How much for this?” she asked with a grimace.

I should ask her for more but—“Two eggs, Mrs. Faroushi,” he declared as he rubbed the soreness from his arm. “For you, two eggs.”

It’s not worth that much! Who does he think he is asking for two good eggs for this bit of rotten rubbish? “How about one?”

“Since you’re a regular,” he agreed. *Hell, they’re all regulars! Just take the damn thing!* He took her egg and she went on her way, peeling off the rotten parts as she walked, leaving very little.

Across the way, a young girl arranged stones into circles on the ground, thinking *this is what it’s like to make dinner for fifty guests* while her mother examined a shawl.

“This is a lovely, colorful thing,” the girl’s mother said. “I wish only that I could have such things. I cannot afford it.”

Nobody can anymore! thought the craftswoman at the stand. “Better days will come!” she said. “The war will end, and things will get better.” *When will this horrible war end?*

Ali Nasser recited by memory as Mullah Mahmoud Aziz leaned over his own Koran to study a point of law.

“Yes, the war will end,” the mother replied before grabbing her daughter by the arm and pulling her home. “And then perhaps I shall buy such a lovely thing, *ensh-Allah.*”

My feast! thought the girl. *My feast has been ruined!* “I want to play, Mama.”

“You can play at home, Fariba.” *Children never stop playing.* “Just come now!” *It’s because of the children that I have no pretty things.*

She would notice me if she knew what I did today, the old fruit vendor thought. *That would let her know I’m not as old as all that.* He straightened out his produce so that it would all be in order when it came time for noon prayer.

They’ll mostly be outside, Ali Nasser reminded himself. *The weather is cold, but clear, so they’ll mostly be outside. It will be quick, then, ensh-Allah.*

“Time to call prayer, Mr. Rezai,” Mullah Aziz reminded his assistant, thinking, *He’ll be gone and I can keep on reading for a while, in peace.*

A pregnant woman puts out a mat for her husband while an old woman, who has already seen her sons grow and be killed in war, embroiders behind the false safety of her

closed door and covered windows. The keeper of the village's only caravanserai does not prepare for the coming call of the muezzin, but instead sits quietly with his friend and plays cards while his cat strolls about searching for scraps.

So many times in a day! Farzad Rezai laments as he stands up and leaves the room. *You'd think they'd come out to prayer on their own. I've never missed a call, but I wonder if they'd all pray without me.*

Clean, you have to be clean, the pregnant woman, who has already prepared her husband's place reminds herself as she scrubs her hands almost raw. *To pray, you have to be clean! There is no room in Paradise for filthy wretches.*

"Let them die quickly," Ali Nasser said aloud. "Let them all be outside so they will get it quickly." He fingered his prayer beads with a few free fingers, concentrating on God's mercy.

Images of a young, blossoming woman's beauty floated about in the old fruit vendor's head as he tried to put words to a *ruba'ai* for her.

The call to *namaz* comes and soon almost everyone in the village is out, bending, praying. Some think and say the required words, others think *How shall I make rice for seven without saffron?* and *I hope he arrives safely in Baneh.* Little boys, even at a tender age proud Kurds, think *If I had a gun I would have shot at those soldiers who passed through town this morning* and *As soon as I can, I will run away and join the freedom fighters in the mountains.*

Mullah Aziz looks out his window and hears something he hasn't heard for a while. *Jet. It sounds like just one.* The echo of the jet carries through the valley as it passes over the village. *Low pass! From the West! Iraqi!*

Thunder! the pregnant woman will think.

"My God!" Mr. Rezai will shout as the jet passes by again, releasing the canisters of sarin and tabun.

My guests have come for the feast! the little girl will imagine.

Ali Nasser whispers and implores soft mercies into his mouthpiece as he drops the many canisters onto the exposed people of the village. On his first pass through the valley he saw them look up, on his second pass he saw those that were still alive run for cover.

El-Bolbol shoots off back to Iraq, no payload remaining. *The Nightingale* has sung its song for them.

The people in the streets die first, followed by those closest to their doors and windows, until finally only a few remain deep in their cellars, but since no one is prepared for this gas, even these are quickly taken. Some bodies lie halfway across a room, inclined toward a cellar door, others lie with hands pressed against their faces, eyes wide open. The last citizen of Abadoun to die will be the unborn child, who could as easily have lived to be a soldier or a savior.

And a man driving to Saqqez had thought, *How much are tomatoes worth in America?*